

A PHOTOSHOP COMPOSITING WORKSHOP

STORMBOUND

Snakefinger: a surreal rainy-scene composite



BUILD THE ILLUSION. EXPLAIN THE DECISIONS.

40 core steps + 4 extensions | Original photographs, editable construction, visual checks and step-specific troubleshooting.

A complete student guide with Why / Check / Fix, process evidence, teacher preflight and assessment support.

Based on the supplied 2009 rainy-scene tutorial by Alvaro Guzman. Updated classroom workflows are identified rather than presented as the original method.

START HERE

The project brief

The task

Create a surreal rainy scene in which a pointing finger becomes a snake. Keep the crow, lightning and rain as part of the original visual idea. Your job is to make separate photographs share convincing contours, light and atmosphere.

What you will practise

Selections and layer masks; Smart Objects; local warping; Clone Stamp and Clone Source rotation; clipped tone adjustments; masked lighting; selective motion blur; two rain depths; surface splashes; visual revision and export.

What has changed

This is an expanded adaptation of the supplied 34-step PDF, not a transcription. The core scene is preserved. Masks replace erasers, local Curves replace destructive burning, and editable source plates make lightning and rain easier to adjust. The default splash route uses only a basic brush.

Route	Expectations
Core / steps 1-40	Complete the hybrid, bird, lightning, two rain layers, small wet details and evidence.
Extensions / steps 41-44	Choose a second texture curve, selective tongue motion, legacy brush comparison or fictional poster.
Supported route	Use a declared prepared cut-out or plate, then separately demonstrate the skill being assessed.

Before you begin

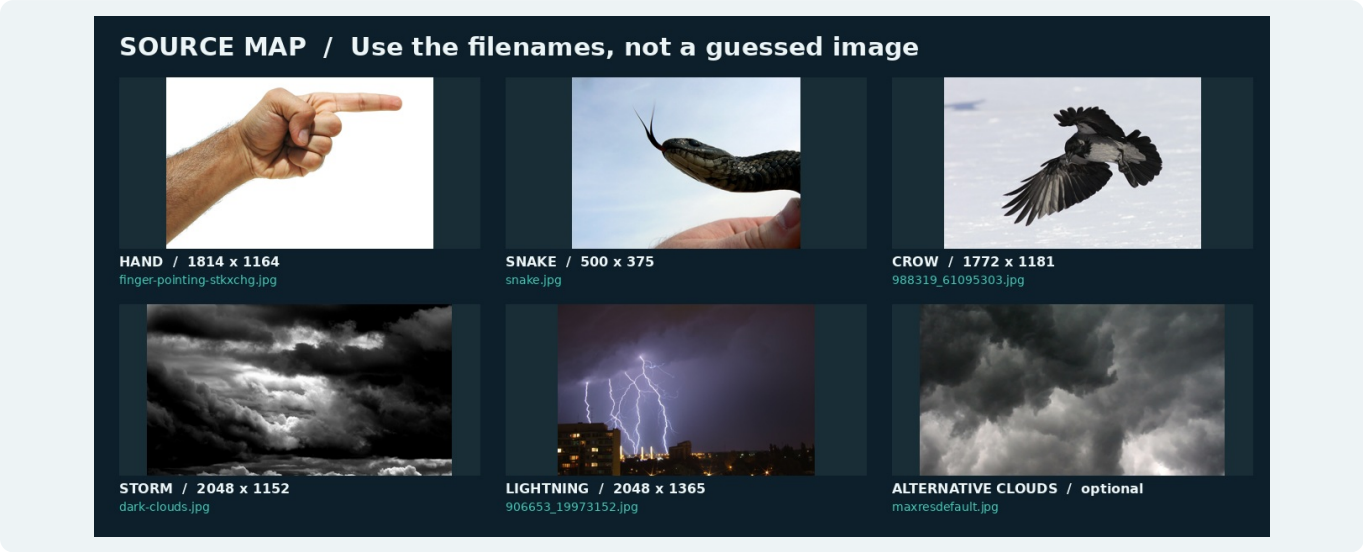
Use Photoshop desktop. No generative tools, paid plug-ins or 3D features are required. Familiarity with layers and the Brush tool helps. Suggested pacing: five to six 70-minute classes, adjusted after the teacher preflight.

Read the pictures correctly

All new checkpoints are source-based teaching composites or diagrams made outside Photoshop. They are not interface screenshots and do not establish an end-to-end Photoshop test. Your own masks, transforms and random noise will produce differences.

KEEP THE FILES ORGANISED

Source images and supports



Five core photographs plus one optional storm alternative. Download filenames exactly as shown.

File	Role / pixels
finger-pointing-stkxchg.jpg	Hand • 1814 × 1164
snake.jpg	Snake head and scales • 500 × 375
988319_61095303.jpg	Flying crow • 1772 × 1181
dark-clouds.jpg	Storm background • 2048 × 1152
906653_19973152.jpg	Photographed lightning • 2048 × 1365
maxresdefault.jpg	Alternative cloud texture • 1920 × 1080

Small source, honest expectations

snake.jpg is only 500 × 375 pixels. Smart Objects prevent additional destructive resampling; they do not invent missing detail. The moderate 1440 × 900 canvas and small head placement are intentional.

Optional support files

The HTML and ZIP include prepared hand, snake and crow cut-outs, a lightning plate, two illustrative rain plates and a small splash. Black backgrounds on Screen plates are intentional. Record any support used in your process notes.

Legacy files

The user’s start.psd, snakefinger.psd and tut_surreal_rain.psd are legacy references, not required starters. Their merged previews were inspected, but their full layer behaviour was not validated. The optional SS-water.abr is in the ZIP; it is not required for the core.

QUICK REFERENCE

Controls that prevent most mistakes

Task	Windows	Mac
Undo	Ctrl+Z	Cmd+Z
Save	Ctrl+S	Cmd+S
Duplicate layer	Ctrl+J	Cmd+J
Free Transform	Ctrl+T	Cmd+T
Deselect	Ctrl+D	Cmd+D
Fit on screen	Ctrl+0	Cmd+0
View 100%	Ctrl+1	Cmd+1
Invert selected mask	Ctrl+I	Cmd+I
Sample Clone Stamp	Alt-click	Option-click
Swap foreground/background	X	X
Default black/white swatches	D, then check foreground	D, then check foreground

Click the correct thumbnail

Image thumbnail = select content. Black-and-white thumbnail = select a mask. A small border shows which one is active. The mask controls visibility; it is not where you sample or paint cloned photograph pixels.

Brush settings are independent

Opacity limits a stroke's strength; Flow controls how quickly paint builds up. Mask colour is equally important: black hides, white reveals. After using Clone Stamp or an imported brush, explicitly reset the tool and size for the next action.

Check tool variants

S may select Pattern Stamp rather than Clone Stamp. W may select a different selection tool. Long-press a toolbar icon to pick the named tool. Menu paths are the reliable fallback when shortcut preferences differ.

Numbers are starting recipes

Pixels refer to the 1440 × 900 main document unless "source image" is stated. A placement width can include transparent margins. Use visual landmarks and linked proportions rather than forcing a mismatched box.

LAYER MASK • FILTER MASK • CLIPPING MASK

Three controls that look similar



The basic visibility rule remains the same throughout the lesson.

Control	What it does	Where you use it
Layer mask	Hides or reveals the actual layer contents. Black means hidden.	Subject extraction; trimming the old fingertip; hiding a blurred duplicate.
Smart Filter mask	Hides or reveals filter effects. Hiding blur restores sharp content.	Controlling a filter; NOT removing the duplicate bird body.
Clipping mask	Limits an upper layer's effect to a base layer's visible shape.	Hand_Tone, Snake_Tone and Crow_Tone.

The inside/outside Smart Object pattern

A masked cut-out is converted to a Smart Object before placement. Its isolation mask then lives inside. An additional outside mask can trim its current placement. Double-click the image thumbnail to edit internal content; save that content tab to update the main document.

A paintable clone target

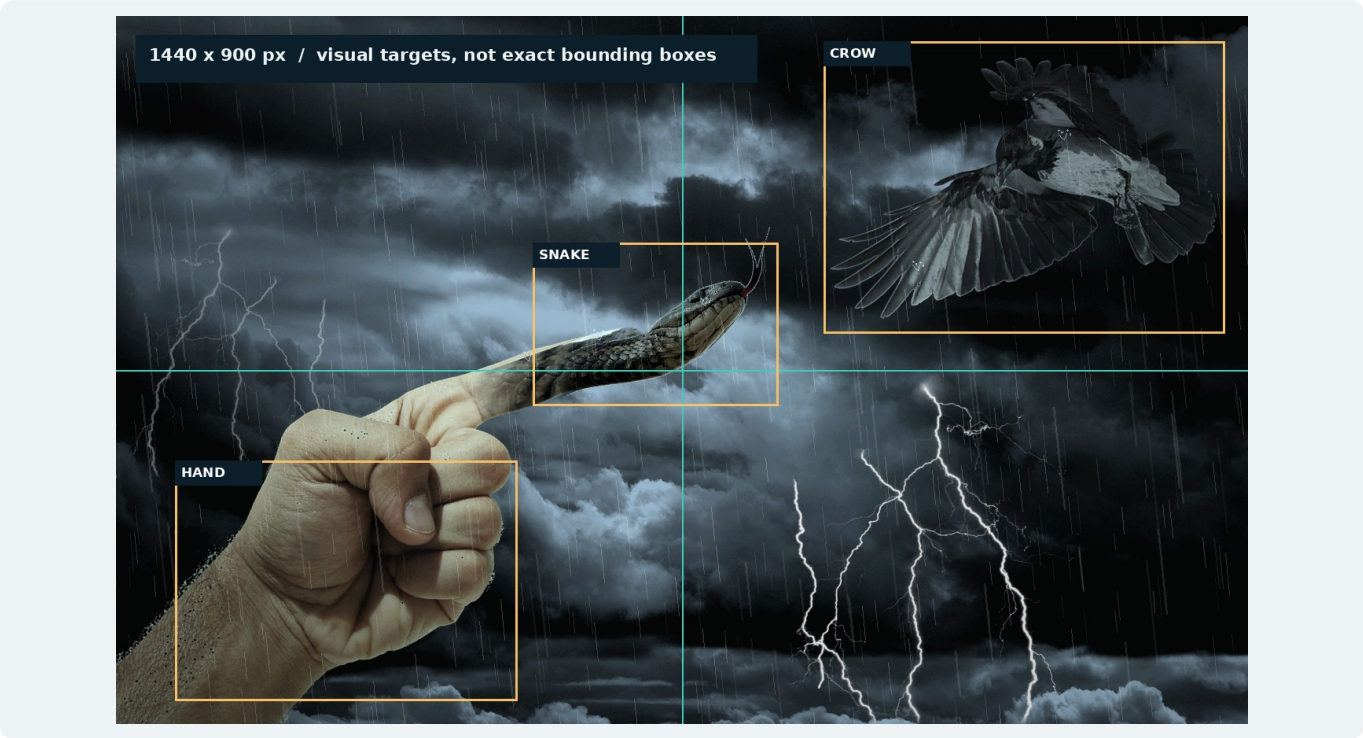
Scale_Clone is deliberately a regular blank pixel layer. It samples the visible neck below while keeping the photographs unchanged. Do not try to clone directly onto a Smart Object or an adjustment mask.

Group boundaries matter

Set HYBRID and CROW groups to Normal. Then an unclipped Curves adjustment inside one group can tone that group's composite without spilling into the background. Leave the group in Pass Through and that behaviour can differ.

STRUCTURE BEFORE EFFECTS

A layout you can use



Top-left canvas origin: x increases to the right, y increases downward. Marked boxes are approximate.

Anchor	Target
Fist centre	Approximately (350, 650); wrist runs off lower left.
Snake root and head	Root around (560, 455); head around (785, 370).
Crow eye	Approximately (1165, 195); visible feathers stay in the upper right.
Main lightning	Lower-right region behind subjects; weaker copy near the left edge.
Critical empty space	Keep the tongue and nearest feather separated by roughly 60 px or more.

What this diagram does not promise

These are visual targets, not a saved Photoshop transform preset. Source canvas margins, selections and warp choices affect exact bounding boxes. Match the flow and silhouette first.

Keep evidence as you go

Evidence 1: clean scale-to-skin join. Evidence 2: justified lighting. Evidence 3: two rain depths. Evidence 4-5: one before/after revision at the same zoom.

01 / PLAN & PREPARE

Plan the transformation, not just the weather

STEP 01 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

The final reference and the original asset thumbnails.



Source-based teaching composite. This is not a Photoshop screenshot or a verified Photoshop render.

1. Create a project folder named Lastname_Stormbound. Inside it make Originals, Working, Exports and Evidence folders. Copy the five core photographs into Originals; never save edits over them.
2. Study the reference: the hand enters from the lower left, the snake continues the finger, and the crow balances the upper right. The open gap between tongue and bird keeps both silhouettes readable.
3. In your notes, identify the main focal point, one secondary subject and the direction of the brightest lightning. Make a tiny sketch with those three anchors.
4. Use the new source-based reference as a composition target, not a pixel-perfect answer. Its processing illustrates the intended relationships; your masks and random rain will differ.

WHY A surreal image can break reality, but its shapes, light and visual hierarchy still need a coherent explanation.

CHECK You can explain the finger-to-snake illusion before naming a filter. The storm supports the transformation rather than hiding it.

FIX Too many competing ideas? Keep one hand, one snake and one bird. Save additional creatures and text for an extension.

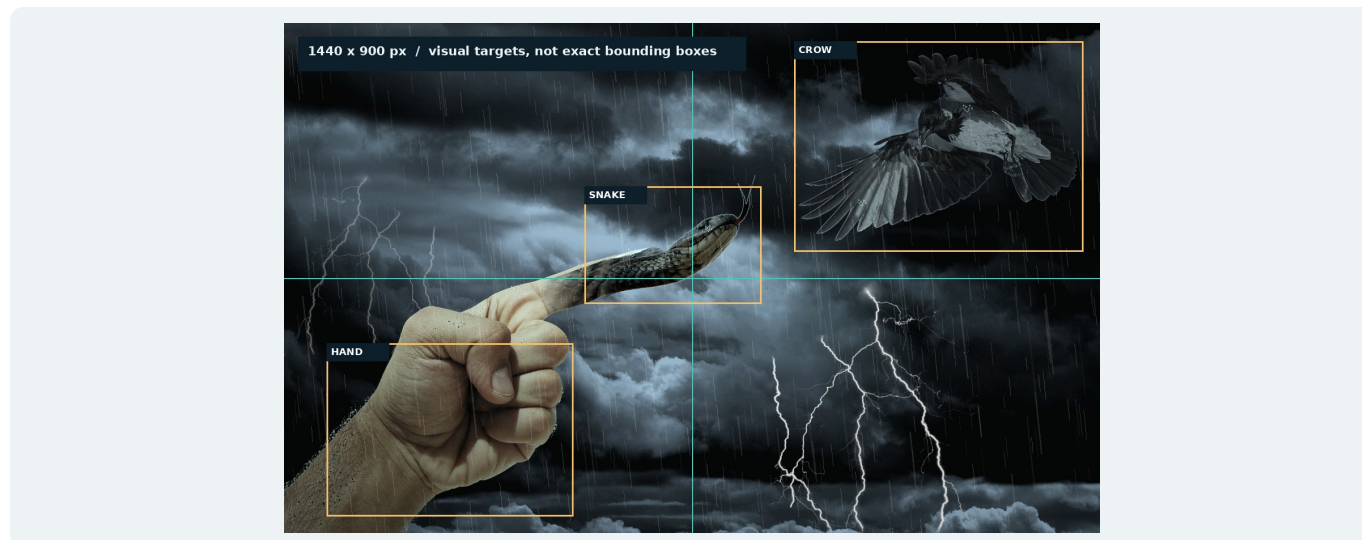
Source relationship: PDF steps 1-2; composition planning expanded. **Tools:** S1.

01 / PLAN & PREPARE

Create the working document

STEP 02 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Photoshop desktop; no image needs to be active.



The blueprint shows visual anchor targets, not exact transform bounding boxes.

1. Choose File > New. Enter Width 1440 pixels, Height 900 pixels, Resolution 72 pixels/inch, RGB Color, 8 bit. Under Advanced Options choose sRGB IEC61966-2.1. Turn Artboards off.
2. Set Background Contents to Black. If the new document is white, select its Background layer and use Edit > Fill > Black. Rename the layer Base_Black and keep it locked.
3. Choose File > Save As and save Working/Lastname_Stormbound_v01.psd. Keep Photoshop layers enabled. A JPEG will be exported only at the end.
4. Open Window > Layers and Window > Properties. Select the Move tool (V) and turn Auto-Select off so you deliberately choose layers. Use View > Fit on Screen, or Ctrl/Cmd+0.

WHY The original canvas is retained. Working at 1440 × 900 limits enlargement of the small snake source; changing the resolution label alone would not add detail.

CHECK Your tab shows a PSD and the document is landscape, 1440 × 900 pixels. You can see the Layers panel.

FIX Dimensions entered in inches? Change the units to pixels. Wrong document open? Read its tab before placing the next file.

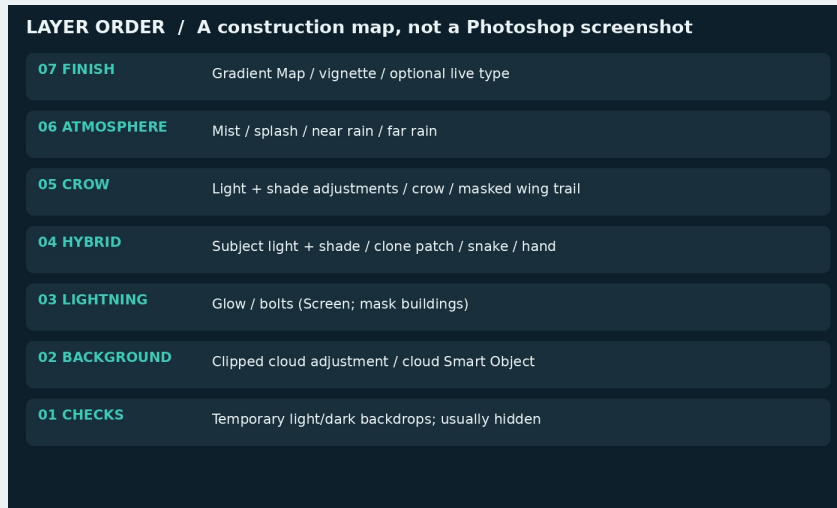
Source relationship: PDF step 1 retained; file management added. **Tools:** S1.

01 / PLAN & PREPARE

Build a layer structure you can understand

STEP 03 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

The main PSD and its Layers panel.



Construction diagram, not a screenshot of the Photoshop interface.

1. Use the folder icon at the bottom of Layers to create seven empty groups. From bottom to top name them 01_CHECKS, 02_BACKGROUND, 03_LIGHTNING, 04_HYBRID, 05_CROW, 06_ATMOSPHERE and 07_FINISH. Leave Base_Black below all groups.
2. Select 04_HYBRID. Change its group blend mode from Pass Through to Normal. Do the same for 05_CROW. Later, adjustments inside these groups will be contained to their contents.
3. Use View > Guides > New Guide to add a vertical guide at 720 px and a horizontal guide at 450 px. These are balance references, not mandatory positions for every object.
4. Leave 01_CHECKS empty for now. When inspecting cut-outs, temporarily hide the Background and Lightning groups; place a white or dark solid-colour layer in CHECKS, beneath the isolated subjects.

WHY Named groups separate object construction, environmental effects and finishing. Normal-mode subject groups make later local lighting easier to control.

CHECK The layer order matches the diagram. HYBRID and CROW show Normal when selected; no subject is hidden behind the clouds.

FIX A layer vanished? Check its group visibility and its position in the stack. Do not erase the background to reveal a misplaced layer.

Source relationship: New classroom organisation; original layer names remain recognisable. **Tools:** S2, S3.

01 / PLAN & PREPARE

Place and tone the storm background

STEP 04 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

02_BACKGROUND in the main PSD.



Cloud tone is a visual target; the supplied grayscale source and your adjustment may differ slightly.

1. Choose File > Place Embedded and select dark-clouds.jpg. Keep proportions linked. In Free Transform, enter a width of 1600 px; its height is 900 px. Centre it on the 1440 × 900 canvas and commit with Enter/Return.
2. Rename it Clouds. Use the layer name, not the image itself, to select it for the next action.
3. Choose Layer > New Adjustment Layer > Curves. Name it Clouds_Tone and tick Use Previous Layer to Create Clipping Mask. In Properties add a midpoint; start with Input 128 and Output 110.
4. Toggle Clouds_Tone off and on. Reduce the change if the darkest clouds lose all texture. The brightest opening should remain available behind the snake and bird.

WHY A clipped adjustment changes only its base layer. We establish background contrast early so subject exposure can be judged against the intended storm.

CHECK The canvas is completely covered. Clouds have both dark masses and readable light openings, without an obvious stretched aspect ratio.

FIX Everything darkens? The Curves layer is not clipped. Select it and choose Layer > Create Clipping Mask. The small downward arrow should point to Clouds.

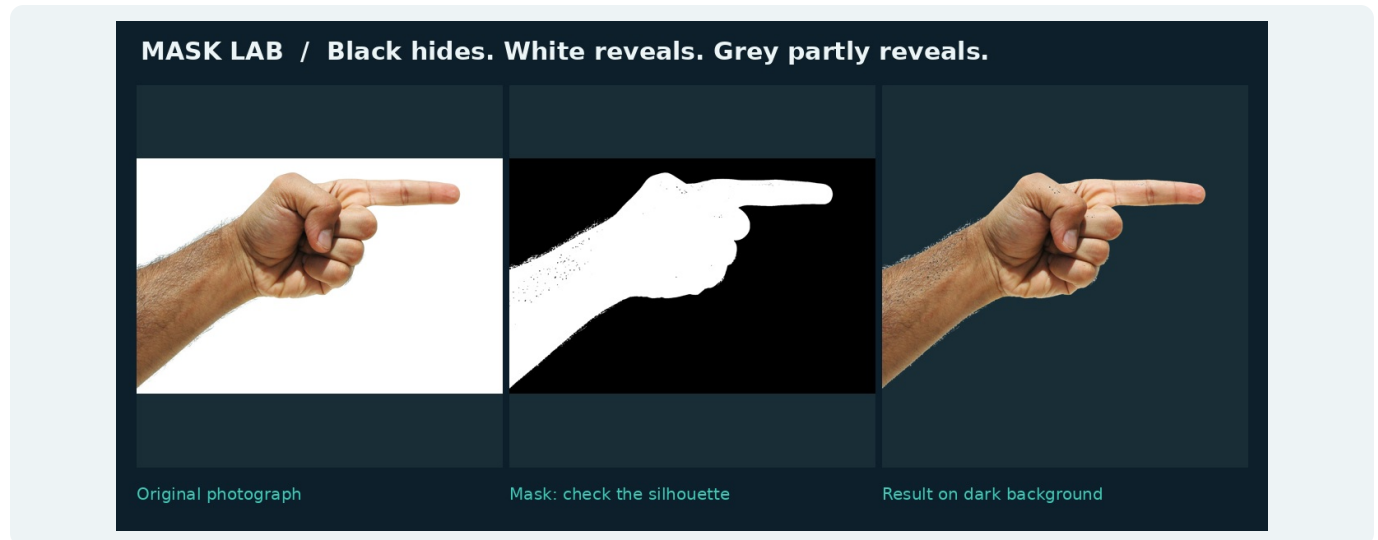
Source relationship: PDF steps 12 and 18 moved earlier; clipped adjustment replaces direct editing. **Tools:** S4, S5.

02 / BUILD THE HYBRID

Mask the hand without deleting it

STEP 05 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

finger-pointing-stkxchg.jpg opened in its own tab.



Mask principle: white reveals, black hides, grey partly reveals. Prepared cut-outs are optional support, not required evidence.

1. Duplicate the Background with Ctrl/Cmd+J. Hide and lock the original. Name the duplicate Hand_Cutout.
2. Choose Select > Subject. When that command is unavailable or inaccurate, use the Quick Selection tool to paint inside the hand and Alt/Option-paint to subtract the white background.
3. Open Select > Select and Mask. Start with Radius 1 px, Feather 0.3 px and Shift Edge -4%. Keep Decontaminate Colors off. View against black and white; use a small Refine Edge Brush only where fine hairs need attention.
4. Set Output To: Layer Mask and confirm. Inspect at 100%. On the mask, black hides remaining white fringe and white restores missing hand. Save Working/Hand_Cutout.psd.

WHY A mask stores visibility separately from the photograph. You can recover a fingertip or a fine edge instead of rebuilding a destructive extraction.

CHECK The hand and index finger are intact. White background is gone, and no heavy pale border appears on a dark check layer.

FIX Painting changes skin colour? You selected the image thumbnail. Click the black-and-white mask thumbnail, then check the brush colour before continuing.

Source relationship: PDF step 2; selection and reversible masking expanded. **Tools:** S2, S6.

02 / BUILD THE HYBRID

Place the hand on the diagonal

STEP 06 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

The masked Hand_Cutout layer, not its hidden original.



Full-image dimensions include transparent margins; judge the marked landmarks rather than forcing an exact box.

1. Right-click the Hand_Cutout layer name and choose Convert to Smart Object. Its isolation mask is now stored inside the object. Select Layer > Duplicate Layer and choose your main PSD as Destination.
2. In the main PSD move the new layer into 04_HYBRID and rename it Hand. Press Ctrl/Cmd+T. With proportions linked, set its full-image width to approximately 943 px, then rotate to about -19°.
3. Place the wrist beyond the lower-left canvas edge. Aim for the centre of the fist near (350, 650) and the original fingertip near (670, 420). Coordinates are measured from the canvas top-left.
4. Commit the transform. Save. These landmark positions take priority over the bounding-box width if your extraction has different transparent margins.

WHY The diagonal leads the viewer into the scene. A Smart Object keeps the source and its mask available while you experiment with placement.

CHECK The hand rises from the lower left, rather than sitting horizontally across the middle. Space remains above and to the right.

FIX The mask moved without the hand? Undo, select the Smart Object image thumbnail and check that any outside mask is linked to the layer before transforming.

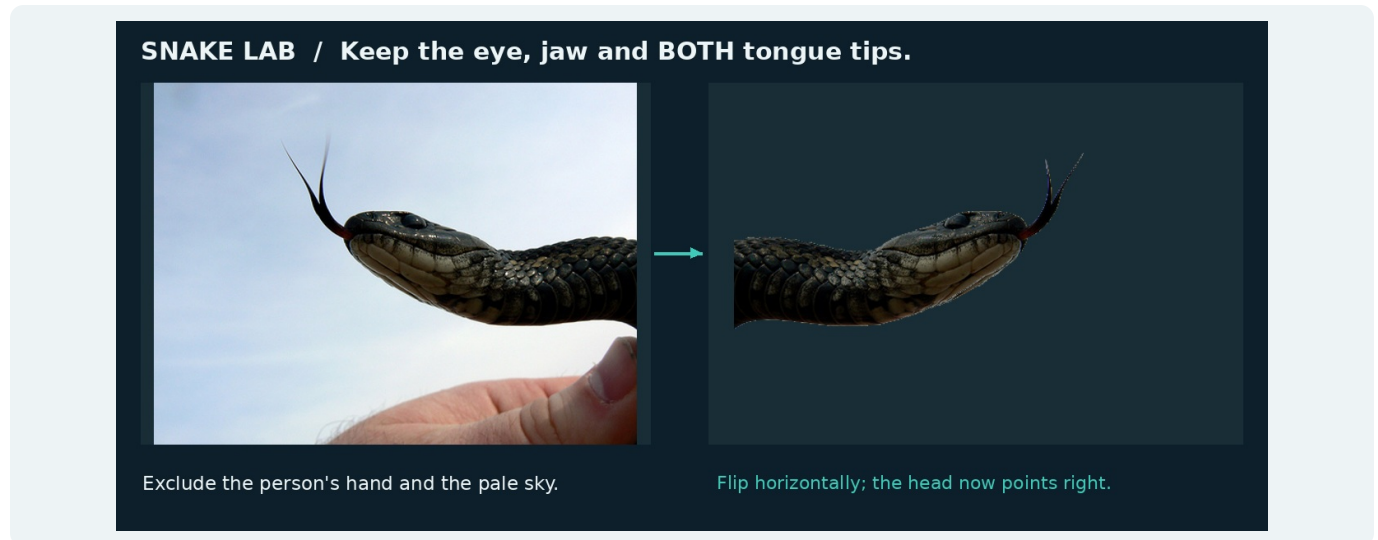
Source relationship: PDF step 2 retained; Smart Object placement added. **Tools:** S3.

02 / BUILD THE HYBRID

Extract the snake and protect its tongue

STEP 07 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

snake.jpg in a separate tab.



The supplied low-resolution snake is preserved. The final head points right after the next step.

1. Duplicate the original layer and hide the original. Use Object Selection in Rectangle mode around the snake head and neck, excluding the person's hand. A careful Polygonal Lasso selection is the fallback.
2. Zoom to 200-300% and add the thin forked tongue to the selection with the Lasso in Add mode. Remove pale sky and the supporting human hand. Do not mistake the tongue for background.
3. Use Select and Mask with Feather about 0.2 px and only a very small edge shift. Output a Layer Mask. Paint small corrections on the mask, checking both a dark and a light temporary background.
4. Convert the masked working layer to a Smart Object. Use Layer > Duplicate Layer to send it to the main PSD, above Hand inside 04_HYBRID. Name it Snake. Save the source tab as Working/Snake_Cutout.psd.

WHY The forked tongue communicates the creature instantly. Its delicate silhouette matters more than an over-smoothed outline.

CHECK You have the head, neck and both tongue tips-no human fingers or pale sky. The source is only 500 × 375 pixels, so some softness is expected.

FIX The tongue disappears in automatic selection? Add it manually on the mask with a tiny white brush. Do not enlarge the file and claim that it creates new detail.

Source relationship: PDF step 3; fine-edge checks added. **Tools:** S2, S3, S6.

02 / BUILD THE HYBRID

Make the snake a continuation of the finger

STEP 08 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Snake Smart Object image thumbnail in the main PSD.



The visible hard seam is intentional at this stage; it will be reconstructed and blended.

1. Choose Edit > Transform > Flip Horizontal so the snake faces right. Keep the head on the right and the cut end of the neck on the left.
2. Use Ctrl/Cmd+T. Begin at about 430 px full-image width with proportions linked. Rotate approximately -15°; move the root toward (560, 455) and the head centre toward (785, 370).
3. Lower Snake opacity temporarily to 60%. Align the neck's centreline with the finger's centreline and keep 30-50 px of overlap. The underside of the jaw should flow from the underside of the finger.
4. Restore opacity to 100% and commit. Keep a clear gap between the tongue and the future bird area.

WHY A convincing transformation starts with structure. Colour and rain cannot fix a neck that points in a different direction from the finger.

CHECK The eye and jaw are not stretched. The finger and neck read as one continuous direction, with enough overlap to blend.

FIX The snake seems pasted on top? Compare both outer contours, not just the centreline. Correct placement now, before cloning over the seam.

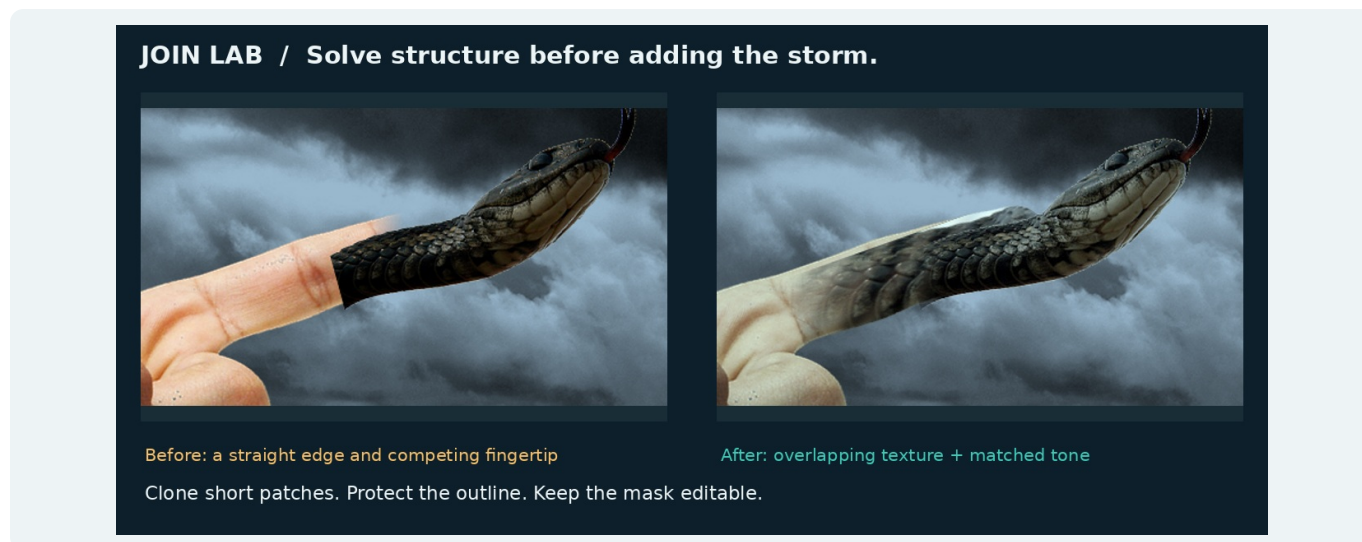
Source relationship: PDF steps 4-5 retained. **Tools:** S3, S7.

02 / BUILD THE HYBRID

Taper the neck without distorting the face

STEP 09 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Snake image thumbnail; no selection should be active.



The left panel shows the structural problem; the right illustrates a blended target.

1. Choose Select > Deselect, then Edit > Transform > Warp. Keep the eye, mouth and tongue in their current positions.
2. Use the warp grid's left edge and nearby handles to reduce the thickness of the cut neck end until it is close to the finger's width—approximately 45-55 px in this layout.
3. Pull the upper-left and lower-left areas inward a little at a time. Do not pull the entire right side or make the jaw narrower. The adjustment should fade out before reaching the face.
4. Commit, then toggle between the before and after using Undo/Redo once. Save only the version that improves the contour. A small rotation correction is preferable to excessive warping.

WHY Tapering the attachment creates a gradual anatomical transition. Stretching the entire snake would make the familiar head proportions look wrong.

CHECK The root fits the finger; the scales near the eye have not become long streaks. The tongue remains sharp enough to recognise.

FIX Warp folds or doubles the edge? Cancel and start with a better scale/rotation. Use a few controlled moves, not many compensating distortions.

Source relationship: PDF step 4 retained; head-protection instructions added. **Tools:** S7.

02 / BUILD THE HYBRID

Hide the old fingertip, not the whole hand

STEP 10 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Hand Smart Object in the main PSD.



Use the seam close-up to compare contours before adding texture.

1. Click the Add Layer Mask icon to give Hand an outside white mask. This is a placement mask; its earlier isolation mask remains inside the Smart Object.
2. Click the new outside mask thumbnail. Use a soft round black brush, roughly 20-35 px, Opacity 100%, Flow 30%.
3. Hide only the old fingertip that protrudes underneath or beyond the snake. Work around the overlap near (610, 445), checking that the neck still covers the hidden region.
4. Press X to switch to white and restore too much masking. Keep part of the original finger under the root: a transparent hole between the two subjects is not a transition.

WHY Two differently shaped fingertips destroy the illusion. Separating isolation from placement makes the edit recoverable without damaging the source cut-out.

CHECK No second human fingertip sticks out. The visible neck meets skin without a gap through to the clouds.

FIX The whole hand vanishes? You may have inverted the entire mask. Fill the outside mask white and repaint only the short protruding tip.

Source relationship: PDF step 5 expanded; nondestructive replacement for trimming. **Tools:** S2, S3.

02 / BUILD THE HYBRID

Lift the snake's detail before sampling it

STEP 11 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Snake layer name, not its mask.



Inspect the scale texture at 100%; low-resolution softness will remain.

1. Choose Layer > New Adjustment Layer > Levels. Name it Snake_Tone and enable Use Previous Layer to Create Clipping Mask.
2. In Levels use RGB. Start with Input Levels 0 / 1.25 / 225 and Output Levels 0 / 255. These are a starting recipe, not measurements copied from the old PDF.
3. Toggle the adjustment. You should see more neck texture without turning the bright jaw white. Reduce the midpoint or move the white input right when highlights clip.
4. Keep this tone stable while cloning. The next step samples the visible texture; changing the underlying tone later does not automatically update already cloned pixels.

WHY Cloning a texture that is far darker than the finger makes a conspicuous patch. Establish a usable source before borrowing it.

CHECK The neck shows individual scales. The adjustment affects Snake only, and the tongue has not acquired a bright halo.

FIX Hand and clouds also brighten? Recreate or correct the clipping mask. An adjustment's mask and a clipping mask are different controls.

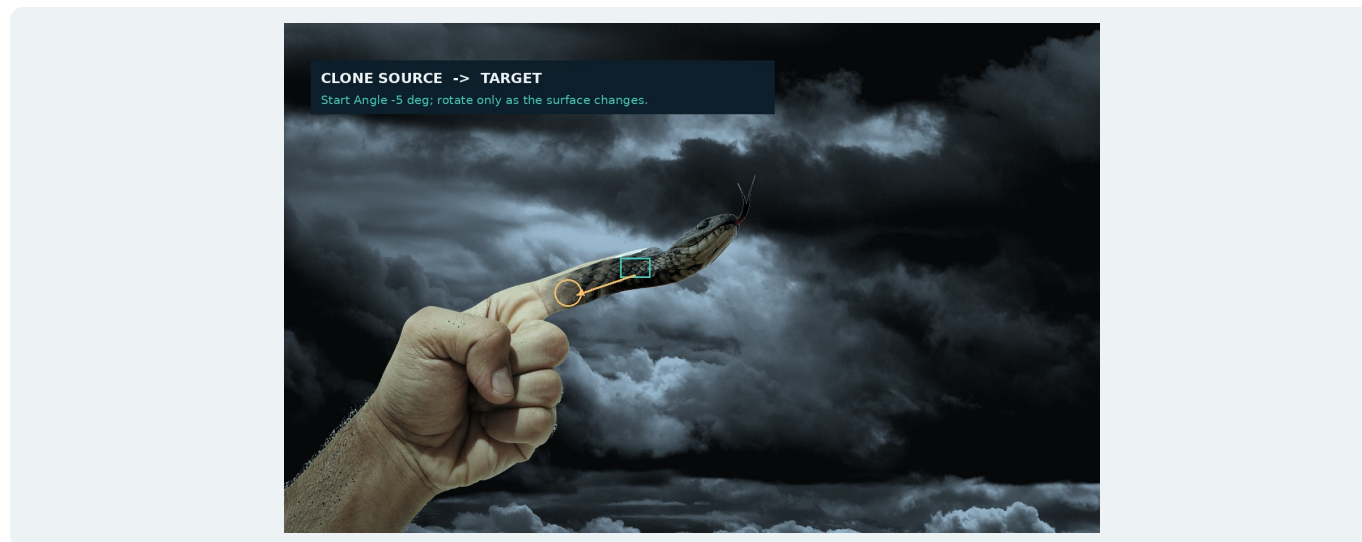
Source relationship: PDF step 6 retained; editable adjustment and sampling caveat added. **Tools:** S4, S5, S8.

02 / BUILD THE HYBRID

Prepare a safe Clone Stamp layer

STEP 12 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

The top of 04_HYBRID, above Snake_Tone and Snake.



Sampling map: borrow an interior neck patch and extend it toward the human finger.

1. Create a new blank pixel layer named `Scale_Clone`. Do not convert this layer to a Smart Object: the Clone Stamp needs a paintable pixel target.
2. Ctrl-click (Windows) or Cmd-click (Mac) the Hand Smart Object image thumbnail to load its stored hand silhouette. Reselect `Scale_Clone` and click Add Layer Mask. The resulting mask limits texture to the hand shape. Deselect.
3. Click `Scale_Clone`'s empty pixel thumbnail-not its mask. Select Clone Stamp (S). Set Sample to Current & Below, Aligned on, Opacity 100%, Flow 30%, Hardness about 30%, Brush Size 20-30 px.
4. Keep source and target in the same main document. The snake must be visible below `Scale_Clone`. The mask is a boundary guard, not a finished texture transition.

WHY Separate-layer cloning leaves the hand and snake intact. Current & Below sees the source photographs without sampling later finishing effects.

CHECK `Scale_Clone` is a blank pixel layer with a hand-shaped mask, and the Clone Stamp options show Current & Below.

FIX Nothing paints? Check the pixel thumbnail, a visible source below it, the Sample setting and whether the target lies inside the white part of the mask.

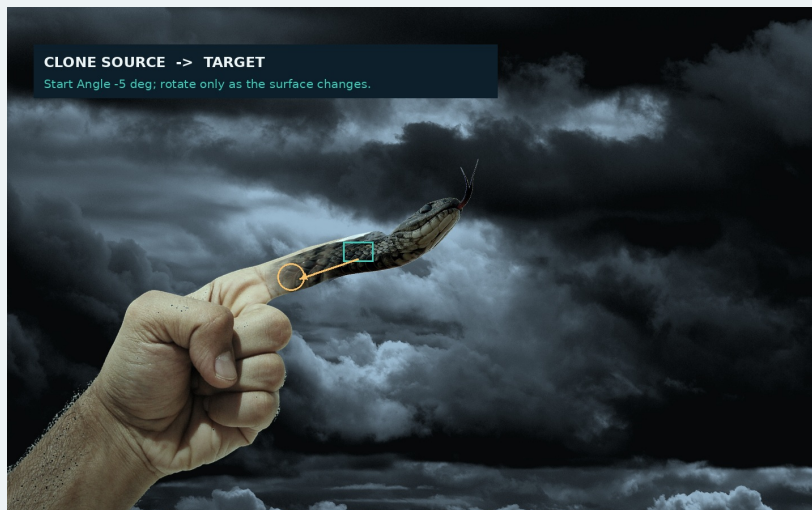
Source relationship: PDF step 7 retained; separate target and silhouette guard added. **Tools:** S8, S9.

02 / BUILD THE HYBRID

Clone scales along the finger's direction

STEP 13 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Scale_Clone pixel thumbnail; Clone Stamp active.



The -5° value comes from the original approach; the correct angle depends on your own transform.

1. Alt-click (Windows) or Option-click (Mac) an interior scale patch on the visible neck, near (620, 430). Avoid the silhouette edge, eye, mouth and tongue.
2. Open Window > Clone Source. Turn Show Overlay on; start its opacity near 40%. Set source rotation to -5° as a first test. Adjust a few degrees to follow your finger rather than copying the number blindly.
3. Paint short strokes from the neck root back across the finger, approximately (575, 460) toward (510, 480). Re-sample two or three different interior patches instead of dragging one long repeated pattern.
4. Use smaller strokes near the finger crease. Keep a strip of natural skin visible toward the knuckle. Reset Clone Source rotation to 0° when finishing so it does not surprise you on the next task.

WHY Scale direction communicates the finger's curve. Repeated eyes, rectangular patches or identical scale clusters expose the edit.

CHECK The texture flows from snake to finger, with no extra eye or repeated jaw. You can point to the sampled source and the separate target layer.

FIX Clouds appear inside the texture? Your sample crossed the snake edge. Undo that stroke, sample farther inside the neck and use a smaller brush.

Source relationship: PDF steps 7-9 retained and expanded. **Tools:** S8, S9.

02 / BUILD THE HYBRID

Blend the scale-to-skin transition

STEP 14 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Scale_Clone mask thumbnail; then Snake's outside layer mask.



Teaching comparison of a hard seam and a reconstructed transition.

1. On the Scale_Clone mask choose a soft black brush, Size 15-30 px, Opacity 100%, Flow 15%. Fade the texture toward the knuckle over approximately 40-70 px.
2. Use uneven small strokes following scale groups rather than one straight vertical fade. Leave enough texture at the neck root to hide the hard join.
3. Add an outside white mask to Snake if it does not have one. With a smaller soft black brush, soften only the left cut edge where the cloned texture bridges to the finger. Protect the face, jaw and tongue.
4. Check at 100%, then 25%. Capture Evidence/01_Join.jpg or a screenshot showing the join and Scale_Clone layer. The effect must work with rain and lightning still absent.

WHY A gradual, irregular transition reads as transformation. A perfect rectangle or an airbrushed blur reads as a pasted photograph.

CHECK Human skin and scales overlap naturally, the crease is still readable and the silhouette remains continuous.

FIX The joint turns see-through? Restore white on the Snake mask and preserve overlap. Do not solve a missing patch by adding more fog.

Source relationship: PDF steps 8-10; masks replace repeated erasing. **Tools:** S2, S8.

02 / BUILD THE HYBRID

Bring the hand into the same colour family

STEP 15 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Hand layer name inside 04_HYBRID.



This cooler hand treatment is a deliberate classroom adaptation of the original greener version.

1. Create a Hue/Saturation adjustment immediately above Hand and clip it to Hand. Name it Hand_Tone; keep it below Snake and Scale_Clone.
2. In Master start with Hue +15, Saturation -30, Lightness -5. Keep Colorize off. These are new starting values for this colder interpretation, not a transcription of the original settings.
3. Compare the skin nearest the scale patch. Reduce the shift when the hand becomes unnaturally flat green. It should retain skin texture, a readable thumbnail and warm/cool variation.
4. Toggle Scale_Clone. If its tone now differs strongly, refine its mask or re-sample a small area; do not keep pushing the entire hand colour just to match one poor patch.

WHY Related colours help separate source photographs feel part of one lighting environment. Colour matching cannot replace a good structural join.

CHECK The hand and neck belong to the same scene, yet the skin-to-scale change remains visible.

FIX Every layer changes colour? The adjustment is outside the subject group or is not clipped. Check the small clipping arrow to Hand.

Source relationship: PDF step 11 retained with revised starting values. **Tools:** S4, S5.

03 / ADD THE SECOND SUBJECT

Isolate the crow's feather silhouette

STEP 16 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

988319_61095303.jpg in a separate tab.



Source and dark-background edge check. This illustrates the inspection task, not an automatic selection result.

1. Duplicate the original, hide it and select the working layer. Use **Select > Subject** or **Quick Selection** to isolate the bird. Add missing feathers; subtract visible pale background between them.
2. Open **Select and Mask**. Start with **Radius 1.5 px**, **Feather 0.3 px** and **Shift Edge -5%**. Use the **Refine Edge Brush** only along difficult feather tips, not across the body.
3. Output a **Layer Mask**. Inspect on light and dark check backgrounds. A large blur is not a substitute for selecting the gaps between feathers.
4. Convert the masked working layer to a **Smart Object**. Duplicate it into the main PSD, move it into **05_CROW** and name it **Crow**. Save the separate source as **Working/Crow_Cutout.psd**.

WHY A recognisable bird shape depends on feather gaps and the beak. Preserving those details makes later motion blur much more convincing.

CHECK The beak and feet remain intact. No solid white triangle bridges two feathers.

FIX Fine pale fringe remains? Refine the mask locally with a small brush or modest negative edge shift. Do not remove the entire feather tip to hide one pixel.

Source relationship: PDF step 14; edge refinement expanded. **Tools:** S2, S6.

03 / ADD THE SECOND SUBJECT

Balance the bird against the snake

STEP 17 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Crow Smart Object image thumbnail.



Landmark targets are approximate; preserve clear silhouettes rather than forcing every coordinate.

1. Use Free Transform with proportions linked. Start with a full-image width near 762 px, then rotate about +8°.
2. Position the visible bird in the upper-right area: roughly $x = 900-1410$ and $y = 30-405$, with its eye near (1165, 195). Transparent margins mean the full layer box is larger.
3. Keep at least about 60 px of clear space between the tongue and the nearest feather. Move or slightly reduce the bird instead of shortening the snake's tongue.
4. View at 25%. The hand-to-snake diagonal should lead toward the bird, while clouds remain visible between the two. Save the composition before adding effects.

WHY The bird provides a secondary focal point and a reason for the snake to point across the image. Separation keeps the visual story readable.

CHECK You can distinguish the tongue, beak and wings at thumbnail size. Neither subject occupies the entire centre.

FIX Everything feels crowded? Reduce the crow by 5-10% and move it upward/right. Do not add more effects to create separation.

Source relationship: PDF step 14 retained. **Tools:** S3, S7.

03 / ADD THE SECOND SUBJECT

Match the crow's exposure

STEP 18 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Crow layer inside 05_CROW.



The tonal checkpoint is intentionally restrained.

1. Add a clipped Curves adjustment named Crow_Tone. Start with a midpoint Input 128 / Output 142 to open the darkest feather detail.
2. Add a clipped Hue/Saturation adjustment above it; start at Saturation -25. Keep both adjustments clipped through the stack to Crow.
3. Toggle both together. The bird should not become a pale grey cut-out or look brighter than the lightning that will be added below it.
4. Leave edge lighting for a later step. Here you are matching overall tone, not drawing individual highlights.

WHY Separating exposure matching from directional lighting makes each decision easier to diagnose and revise.

CHECK The crow remains dark, but feather texture is visible. The snowy source background has not returned.

FIX Bird looks washed out? Reduce the Curves lift. Check against the clouds at 100% and at 25%, not only on the white source image.

Source relationship: PDF step 15; adjustment layers replace direct dodge/burn for initial tone. **Tools:** S4, S5.

04 / LIGHT THE SCENE

Prepare a lightning plate without buildings

STEP 19 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

906653_19973152.jpg in a separate tab.



The prepared support plate has a black background by design; it is not a transparent PNG.

1. Duplicate the photograph, hide its original and name the working copy Bolts_Source. Use the Rectangular Marquee or Lasso to select sky containing a useful branching bolt.
2. For this source, begin around $x = 390$ to 1010 and $y = 265$ to 1060 . These source-image coordinates are a starting crop only. Exclude every roof, antenna, bridge light and bright window with the selection or its mask.
3. Click Add Layer Mask to retain the selected sky. On the mask, use a soft black brush to trim the perimeter while keeping the fine branches.
4. Convert the masked layer to a Smart Object. Duplicate it into 03_LIGHTNING in the main PSD, below the subjects, and name it Bolts_Plate. Save the separate source PSD.

WHY Screen blending will reveal bright windows as readily as bright lightning. Removing buildings first prevents accidental city fragments in the storm.

CHECK Only a region of sky with lightning remains. A temporary black background reveals no roof silhouette or orange city lights.

FIX A bright speck survives near the base? Check the source crop; it may be a building light rather than a bolt. Mask it deliberately.

Source relationship: PDF step 19 retained; extraction checks expanded. **Tools:** S2, S3.

04 / LIGHT THE SCENE

Use Screen with a controlled dark background

STEP 20 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Bolts_Plate Smart Object in the main document.



Photo extraction plus tonal separation; no hand-drawn replacement of the photographed bolt is required.

1. Double-click the Bolts_Plate image thumbnail to open its contents. Inside, add Hue/Saturation above the source and set Saturation to -100.
2. Add a Levels adjustment above Hue/Saturation. Start with RGB Input Levels 136 / 0.85 / 247. Move the black input until most sky becomes black while the finest important branches survive.
3. Save the Smart Object contents with Ctrl/Cmd+S and return to the main PSD. Set Bolts_Plate's layer blend mode to Screen.
4. Inspect for a pale rectangular plate. If it appears, darken the source sky further inside the object and soften the outside layer mask. Keep a little natural glow close to the bolt, not across its entire photo rectangle.

WHY Screen leaves black unchanged and adds the brighter content. The old tutorial uses Vivid Light; this controlled Screen plate is a deliberate alternative for easier troubleshooting.

CHECK The bolt brightens the existing clouds without covering them with purple sky or a rectangular veil.

FIX All lightning disappears? The black point is too aggressive or the wrong mask is black. Reopen the plate and lower the black input; judge the image, not just the starting values.

Source relationship: PDF step 20 adapted: Vivid Light replaced with Screen and an editable plate. **Tools:** S3, S10.

04 / LIGHT THE SCENE

Position the bolts and establish the light source

STEP 21 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Bolts_Plate, still inside 03_LIGHTNING.



Two related bolt placements form an intentional lighting hierarchy.

1. Use Free Transform to place the main visible bolt on the lower-right side, approximately $x = 850-1265$, $y = 370-900$. Keep the lightning behind the hand, snake and bird.
2. Duplicate the plate with Ctrl/Cmd+J. Flip the copy horizontally, reduce its visible size to roughly 70% of the first, move most of it toward the left edge, and lower its opacity to 35-40%.
3. Create a blank layer above the bolts but still in 03_LIGHTNING. Name it Bolt_Glow. With a very soft brush, colour #C7E8F1 and low Flow (5-10%), paint one restrained glow around the main bright branching region.
4. Keep the strongest light on the right/lower-right. In your notes, mark which surfaces of the hand and bird face it. The weaker left bolt is an accent, not an equal second sun.

WHY A visible light source gives the next highlights a reason to exist. Layer order also prevents lightning from cutting through the foreground anatomy.

CHECK The main bolt is clear without overpowering the snake eye. No building detail appears. The left accent is quieter.

FIX Lightning crosses the hand? Move the whole Lightning group below Hybrid and Crow. Do not erase parts of the hand to reveal it.

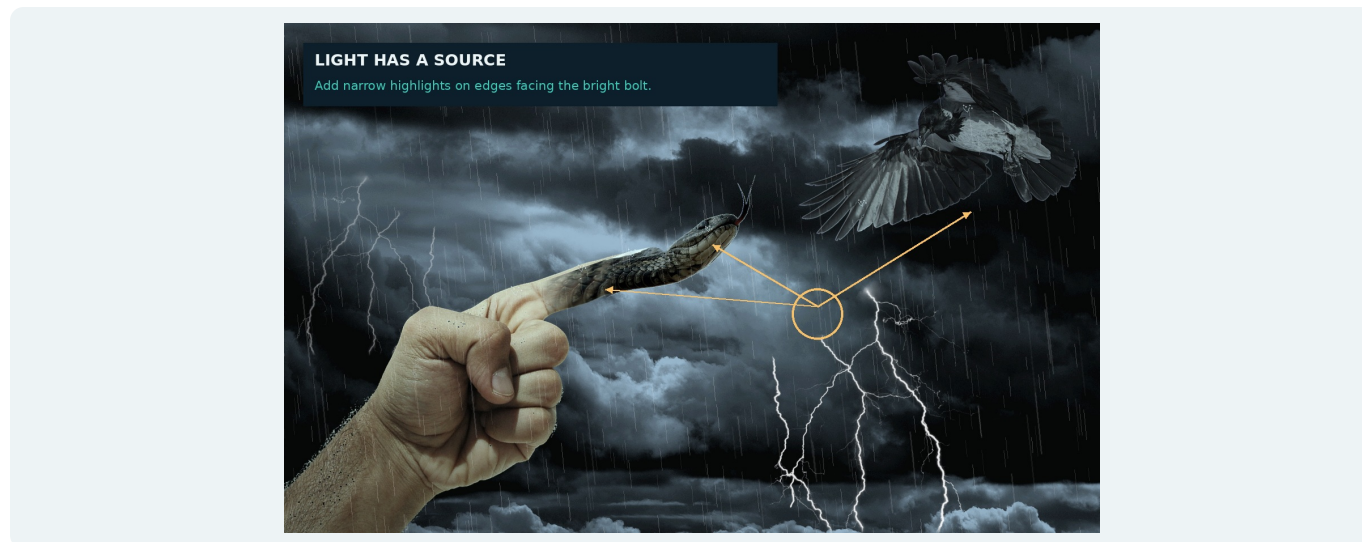
Source relationship: PDF steps 19 and 22 retained; explicit light hierarchy added. **Tools:** S2, S10.

04 / LIGHT THE SCENE

Shape the subjects with editable shade

STEP 22 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

The top of 04_HYBRID; group blend mode must be Normal.



Light-direction teaching diagram. This airborne scene does not need a ground-contact shadow.

1. Create a Curves adjustment at the top INSIDE 04_HYBRID. Name it Hybrid_Shade. Use Input 128 / Output 98 as a starting midpoint; do not clip it to only the nearest layer.
2. Click its white adjustment mask and press Ctrl/Cmd+I to turn it black. The image returns to its previous appearance.
3. Paint white on this mask with a soft 40-90 px brush, Flow 8-12%. Darken the lower fist, recesses between curled fingers and areas that turn away from the brightest bolt.
4. Check that the clouds do not change. For the bird, repeat inside the Normal-mode Crow group only when needed, using a smaller, gentler adjustment. Never fill all feather detail with black.

WHY Black masks let you reveal an adjustment locally. This replaces the original high-exposure Burn strokes with an edit that can be reduced, hidden or repainted.

CHECK The hand retains texture and volume. Shaded surfaces agree with the chosen light direction; the whole background has not darkened.

FIX The entire scene changes? Move the adjustment inside Hybrid and set that group to Normal rather than Pass Through.

Source relationship: PDF step 13 adapted: masked Curves replace direct Burn at 50% exposure. **Tools:** S2, S5.

04 / LIGHT THE SCENE

Add light only where a surface faces it

STEP 23 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

The top of 04_HYBRID, above Hybrid_Shade.



Reference lighting was approximated programmatically; use this as a direction and restraint check.

1. Create Curves named Hybrid_Light, midpoint 128 / 174. Invert its mask to black. With a soft white brush at Flow 5-10%, add broad but subtle light on the jaw and finger surfaces facing the main bolt.
2. Shrink the brush to 2-5 px for a few broken edge accents. Follow the lower-right-facing jaw and selected scales; do not trace a continuous line around the whole hand.
3. Repeat with a masked Crow_Light adjustment inside 05_CROW, revealing light on selected lower feather edges facing the bolt. Keep the eye and beak readable.
4. Toggle each lighting layer. A successful change adds shape without making a glowing sticker. Save Evidence/02_Lighting.jpg with your light direction explained.

WHY Local highlights connect different source photographs to the same invented lighting environment. Their direction matters more than their brightness.

CHECK Edges facing the bolt receive more light than edges facing away. Feather and scale detail still has tonal variation.

FIX White outline around everything? Reduce the light mask with black or lower the adjustment opacity. Use fewer, broken highlights rather than a full contour.

Source relationship: PDF steps 15 and 21 retained; highlights moved to masked adjustments. **Tools:** S2, S5.

05 / MOTION & RAIN

Blur the wings while keeping the head sharp

STEP 24 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Crow Smart Object image layer, below its clipped tone adjustments.



This restrained 20 px starting distance is a deliberate reduction from the older dramatic blur.

1. Duplicate Crow and place the copy directly below it inside 05_CROW. Name the copy Wing_Motion. Choose Filter > Blur > Motion Blur; start at Angle -30°, Distance 20 px.
2. Alt-click (Windows) or Option-click (Mac) Add Layer Mask to create a black OUTSIDE layer mask on Wing_Motion. The whole duplicate should disappear.
3. Paint white on this outside mask only around the outer wing tips and tail. Keep the head, eye, beak and centre of the body hidden on the blurred duplicate. Start layer opacity around 35%.
4. Do not use the Smart Filters mask for this isolation: hiding a filter restores sharp pixels; it does not hide the whole duplicate. Preserve the original sharp Crow above.

WHY A narrow motion trail suggests movement while retaining a recognisable bird. The layer-mask/filter-mask distinction prevents a ghosted second head.

CHECK Only the tips trail slightly. The crow has one clear eye and one sharp beak, not two overlapping bodies.

FIX Blur is a giant smudge? Lower Distance and opacity. A duplicate too far below the adjusted bird may also need a modest tonal match.

Source relationship: PDF step 16 retained; editable filter and correct duplicate isolation added. **Tools:** S2, S11.

05 / MOTION & RAIN

Create a separate, editable rain source

STEP 25 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

A new document, not an existing subject layer.



Recipe diagram only: the exact random pattern will differ in Photoshop.

1. Choose File > New: 1440 × 900 pixels, RGB, 8 bit, black background. Name this document Rain_Source.
2. Convert its black Background to a Smart Object with Filter > Convert for Smart Filters. Rename it Noise_Seed.
3. Save Working/Rain_Source.psd. Keep this source separate from the main composition while building the effect.
4. Remember the sequence: noise makes random spots, motion blur stretches them, Levels isolates the brighter streaks, and Screen blends the dark plate. You are making the rain yourself, not downloading a finished weather effect.

WHY A separate source makes the filter sequence easy to inspect and revise before perspective, scale and blending complicate it.

CHECK You have a black Rain_Source document with one Smart Object called Noise_Seed. The main artwork remains unchanged in its own tab.

FIX Noise appears on the hand? Undo. Read the active document tab and select Noise_Seed before applying any filter.

Source relationship: PDF step 23 retained; separate source workflow added. **Tools:** S3, S11.

05 / MOTION & RAIN

Stretch noise into rain streaks

STEP 26 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Noise_Seed Smart Object inside Rain_Source.psd.



The numeric 400% / 90° / 100 px recipe is retained from the supplied PDF.

1. Choose Filter > Noise > Add Noise. Enter Amount 400%, select Gaussian and tick Monochromatic. Confirm. The black canvas becomes dense grayscale noise.
2. Choose Filter > Blur > Motion Blur. Enter Angle 90° and Distance 100 px. Confirm. The noise becomes fine vertical streaks.
3. Expand Smart Filters in Layers. Photoshop applies the list from bottom to top: Add Noise should be below Motion Blur. Double-click either name later to reopen its settings.
4. Do not expect finished rain yet. The grey veil is normal at this intermediate stage; the following Levels adjustment separates the streaks.

WHY The original noise-and-blur method is retained, but its parameters are now reopenable instead of being permanently baked into a pixel layer.

CHECK There are two named Smart Filters and the streaks are vertical. Coloured speckles mean Monochromatic was not enabled.

FIX Streaks run horizontally? Check Angle 90°. Nothing changes? Confirm the filter is enabled and you are viewing Noise_Seed at a useful zoom.

Source relationship: PDF steps 24-25 retained. **Tools:** S1, S11.

05 / MOTION & RAIN

Separate bright rain from the grey veil

STEP 27 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Noise_Seed in Rain_Source.psd.



Read the target appearance as well as the numbers; the original settings are a starting point.

1. Create a Levels adjustment ABOVE Noise_Seed. Name it Rain_Contrast. Use Input Levels 120 / 0.40 / 180 as the initial recipe; these values are visible in the source PDF's page 42 screenshot.
2. Inspect at 100%. Aim for sparse thin light streaks on a mostly black background. Move the black input slowly to control density; change the white input only enough to retain distinct brighter streaks.
3. If almost everything disappears, reduce the black input. If the image remains a pale curtain, increase it. Noise is random, so the same numbers may not produce the best density every time.
4. Save Rain_Source.psd before wrapping the layers in the next step. Do not merge or flatten them.

WHY Screen would lighten the entire scene if the grey veil remained. Contrast separation controls how much rain survives the blend.

CHECK Black occupies most of the plate and the remaining streaks are varied, not a solid curtain.

FIX The effect is weak after Screen? First inspect the plate alone. Raising opacity will not rescue a plate with no surviving streaks.

Source relationship: PDF step 27 and page 42 screenshot retained. **Tools:** S1, S10.

05 / MOTION & RAIN

Place the far rain as one complete plate

STEP 28 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Both Rain_Contrast and Noise_Seed in Rain_Source.psd.



The far-rain proof uses equivalent illustrative streaks, not an exact Photoshop noise render.

1. Shift-click to select the two layers together. Right-click and choose Convert to Smart Object. The new outer object contains the filter seed and the Levels adjustment; rename it Rain_Far.
2. Choose Layer > Duplicate Layer and send Rain_Far to the main PSD. Put it inside 06_ATMOSPHERE. Set its layer blend mode to Screen and opacity to 30%.
3. Use Free Transform to enlarge it to 125% of its current size, centre it, and rotate about -6°. Judge the streak direction visually: use one consistent slight diagonal and ensure every canvas edge remains covered.
4. Commit. Double-clicking the outside Rain_Far object opens its internal recipe when you need to revise it. Save the main document as v02.

WHY Wrapping the complete plate before transforming means contrast and filtered streaks travel together. The source recipe remains editable inside.

CHECK Fine rain crosses the scene without a grey rectangle or uncovered corner. Subjects remain easy to see.

FIX Transform seems to change the filter rather than just the finished streaks? Confirm the Levels layer and filtered seed were wrapped together before the outer transform.

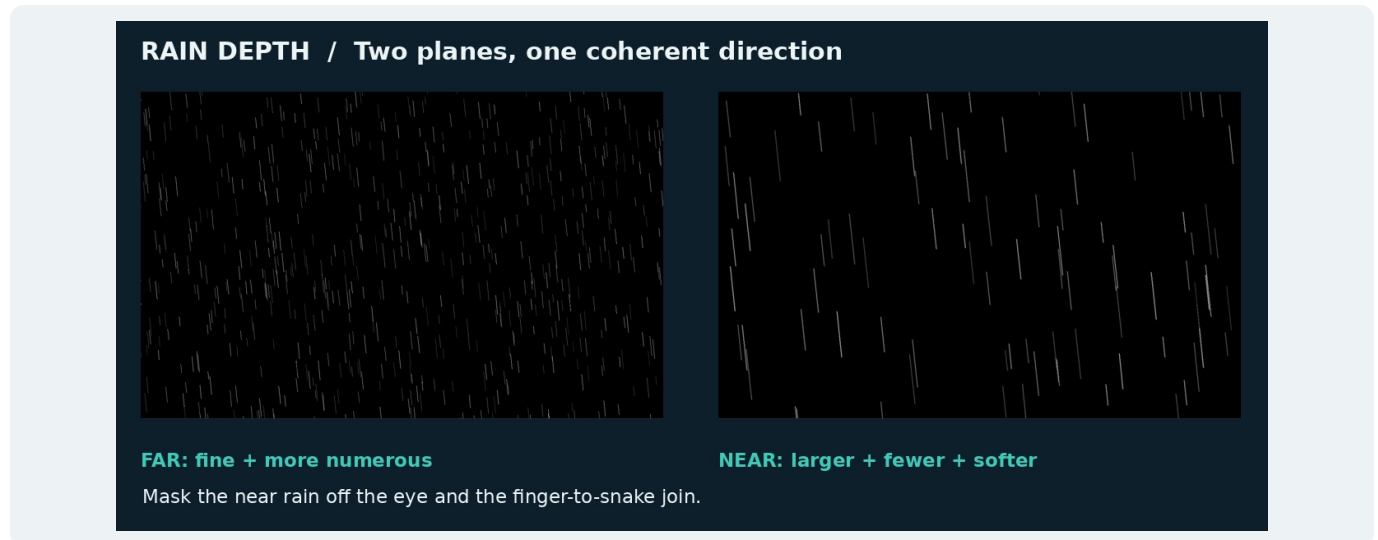
Source relationship: PDF steps 26 and 28 adapted; small common slant replaces aggressive perspective in the core. **Tools:** S3, S10, S11.

05 / MOTION & RAIN

Add a quieter near-rain layer

STEP 29 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Rain_Far in the main PSD.



Two planes illustrate depth; they are not two unrelated storms blowing in different directions.

1. Choose Layer > Smart Objects > New Smart Object via Copy. Rename it Rain_Near and keep it above Rain_Far. This makes an independent recipe for density changes.
2. Enlarge the copy to approximately 1.8 times the far-rain plate's width, maintaining proportions. Offset its centre about 180 px to the right. Keep the same rain angle.
3. Apply Filter > Blur > Gaussian Blur, Radius 0.8 px, to the outer object. Set Screen opacity between 15% and 25%. Use a lower opacity when the scene looks busy.
4. If too many large streaks remain, open Rain_Near's contents and raise Rain_Contrast's black input slightly, then save. That change should not affect Rain_Far.

WHY Larger, softer and less numerous streaks provide a second depth plane. A shifted copy prevents every large streak from lying exactly over its small counterpart.

CHECK You can distinguish fine far rain from a few softer near streaks. Both share one wind direction.

FIX Both rain layers change when you edit one? You used a linked duplicate. Undo and use New Smart Object via Copy for independent contents.

Source relationship: PDF step 29 expanded with independent-source control. **Tools:** S3, S11.

05 / MOTION & RAIN

Protect the eyes and the transformation

STEP 30 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Rain_Near outside layer mask, added white if needed.



Keep fine rain continuous; reduce only the distracting larger near streaks.

1. Click Add Layer Mask on Rain_Near. Select the mask and use a soft black brush, Size 60-100 px, Opacity 100%, Flow 15%.
2. Lightly reduce near rain over the crow's eye and beak, the snake's eye/tongue and the scale-to-skin transition. Keep some fine Rain_Far visible there.
3. Toggle both rain layers off and on at 25% zoom. Reduce their opacity together if rain becomes the first thing you notice.
4. Take Evidence/03_Rain_Depth.jpg showing both rain layers and a short explanation of why their size, softness and opacity differ.

WHY Effects should support the focal information, not conceal the hardest compositing work. Selective reduction preserves a believable storm without sacrificing readability.

CHECK The eyes and join are visible through the weather. There are no suspiciously hard-edged rain-free holes.

FIX Mask looks like a cut-out circle? Use a larger soft brush at lower flow, then restore some white to make the transition gradual.

Source relationship: New focal-control check following original step 29. **Tools:** S2.

06 / WET DETAILS & FINISH

Suggest wet surfaces with small highlights

STEP 31 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

A new blank pixel layer named Wet_Specular in 06_ATMOSPHERE.



Wet highlights and splashes are kept small relative to the hand and feathers.

1. Choose a hard round brush, colour #D6EFF5, size 1-2 px at this canvas scale. Start with layer opacity 50% and brush opacity 100%.
2. Paint a few short, broken marks on upper finger contours, raised scales and selected feather edges near the light. Follow the surface direction rather than drawing random white scratches.
3. Leave broad skin and dark feather areas unpainted. A few bright reflected details are enough to suggest moisture.
4. Add a white layer mask and remove unconvincing marks with black. Toggle this layer at 100% and 25% to judge whether it improves material rather than making everything shiny.

WHY Rain in the air and wetness on a surface are different cues. Controlled specular details help connect the two.

CHECK Small highlights catch the light without becoming long neon outlines or white painted patches.

FIX Surfaces look metallic? Reduce highlight coverage, not just opacity. Keep marks broken and aligned with the material.

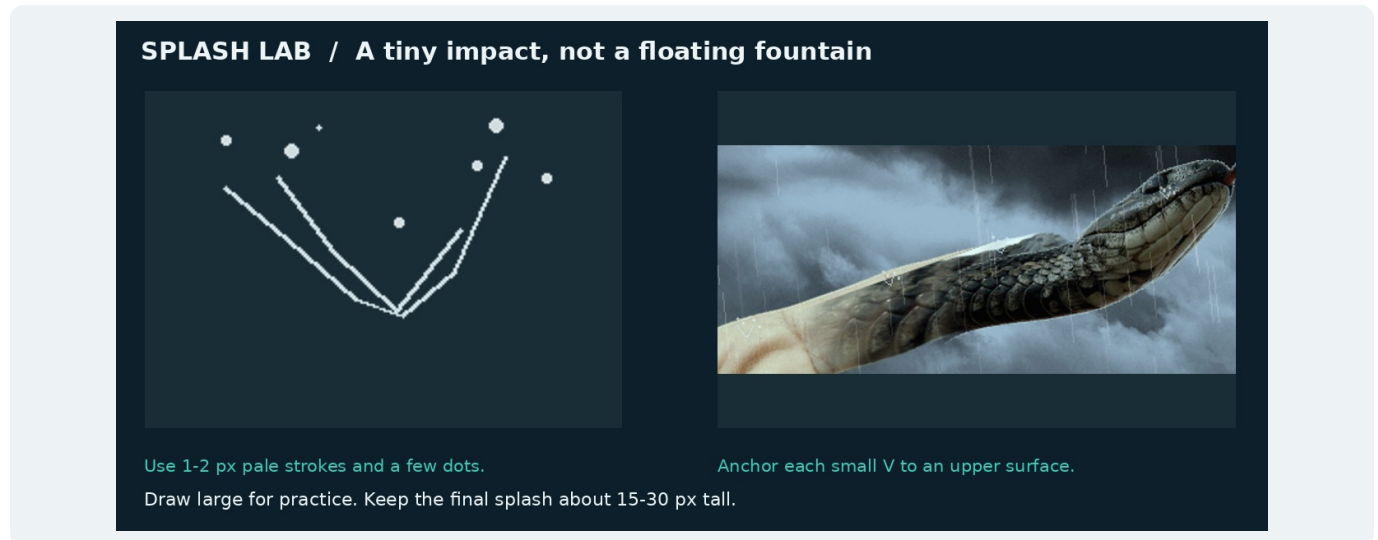
Source relationship: PDF steps 21 and 30-32 expanded into separate surface and impact cues. **Tools:** S2.

06 / WET DETAILS & FINISH

Build a tiny splash with a basic brush

STEP 32 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

New blank layer Splash_01 above Wet_Specular.



The enlarged sketch explains construction; the final splash is much smaller.

1. Choose a hard round brush with colour #D6EFF5 and size 1-2 px. Zoom in for control; the final splash should be only about 15-30 px tall.
2. Draw two short, shallow arcs or a small open V rising from one point on the upper edge of the finger. Add three to five tiny dots above the arcs, varying their size slightly.
3. Use Free Transform to rotate and scale the mark so its base touches the surface—for example near (525, 438). Lower layer opacity to 40-65% as needed.
4. Add a mask to hide any stroke below the skin contour. Keep the impact attached to the surface, not hovering in the air.

WHY The lesson's wet-surface effect does not have to depend on an old custom brush. A small, well-placed impact is more convincing than a large decorative fountain.

CHECK The splash has one contact point, a few droplets and a tiny scale. It follows the surface rather than pointing out of the finger sideways.

FIX Looks like a white plant? Make it smaller and simpler. Most detail should be suggested, not diagrammed at full size.

Source relationship: PDF step 30 adapted; basic-brush route replaces a required legacy preset. **Tools:** S1.

06 / WET DETAILS & FINISH

Vary impacts and drifting droplets

STEP 33 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Splash_01 layer and its mask.



Impact locations are suggestions, not a requirement to cover every surface.

1. Duplicate Splash_01 two or three times. Reduce each copy to 40-80% of the original, rotate a little, and place on different upper finger/scale edges. Do not distribute evenly.
2. On a separate Drops layer, paint a few 1-3 px pale dots near the crow's outer feathers. Use lower opacity for more distant droplets.
3. Change or mask part of each repeated splash so the copies are not visibly identical. Keep the bird's eye, the tongue and the hand-to-snake join unobstructed.
4. Group these small layers within 06_ATMOSPHERE under a subgroup named Wet_Details. Toggle it to confirm the marks add only a restrained finishing cue.

WHY Variation in size, spacing and opacity prevents an obvious stamped pattern. Tiny impacts suggest that rain interacts with the subjects.

CHECK You see a wet scene, not a row of matching white symbols. Every impact on the hand touches an upper-facing surface.

FIX Drops resemble snow? Use fewer, smaller and less opaque dots. Rain streaks should remain the main airborne weather cue.

Source relationship: PDF steps 31-32 retained with non-brush-pack alternatives. **Tools:** S1.

06 / WET DETAILS & FINISH

Use mist sparingly to separate depth

STEP 34 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

New blank layer named Mist at the top of 06_ATMOSPHERE.



Mist is a small new finishing option, not a substitute for masking.

1. Choose a very soft round brush, colour #AECBD0, Size 300-500 px, Flow 3-5%. Paint one or two broad low-opacity passes in an empty cloud region between the subjects.
2. Set the layer opacity initially to 8-15%. Keep the effect subtle; the scene already contains cloudy source material.
3. Add a white mask and remove mist from the eyes, scale-to-skin join and sharp silhouette tips. Avoid a continuous veil over the whole canvas.
4. Toggle Mist. Leave it hidden when the image reads better without it. An unused optional effect is a valid design decision; explain your choice in the notes.

WHY Atmosphere can separate depths, but overuse flattens contrast and hides craftsmanship. Restraint is part of the skill.

CHECK Depth improves without losing the snake's shape or the bird's expression.

FIX Everything looks milky? Lower opacity or omit the layer. Do not darken all other layers just to compensate for excessive fog.

Source relationship: New classroom addition; not a required step in the old PDF. **Tools:** S2.

06 / WET DETAILS & FINISH

Unify colour without crushing contrast

STEP 35 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

07_FINISH group above all image and weather groups.



New colour-focused grade; compare with the original reference rather than assuming identical settings.

1. Choose Layer > New Adjustment Layer > Gradient Map. Name it Global_Grade. Click the gradient strip in Properties to open its editor.
2. Use two stops: the left at Location 0% with colour #132630; the right at 100% with #D6E6DC. Keep Reverse off. Confirm the editor.
3. Change the adjustment layer blend mode to Color and opacity to 20%. This adds a restrained shared colour family while largely preserving underlying luminosity.
4. Toggle the grade at 25% and 100%. Reduce opacity if the skin loses all warmth. The original PDF uses a black-to-white Gradient Map in Overlay at 35%; this is an explicitly different colour-focused finish.

WHY A common colour bias helps integrate multiple photographs. Applying it after local corrections means it unifies already coherent work rather than disguising mismatches.

CHECK Dark clouds remain detailed, the hand is not uniformly green and lightning keeps a bright core.

FIX Image turns entirely dark teal and pale grey? Check that blend mode is Color, opacity is 20%, and you have not left the adjustment in Normal at 100%.

Source relationship: PDF step 34 adapted; revised gradient, mode and strength are labelled. **Tools:** S10.

06 / WET DETAILS & FINISH

Guide attention with an editable vignette

STEP 36 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

07_FINISH above Global_Grade.



Finishing is subtle; this is not a requirement to make every corner black.

1. Add Curves named Vignette. Start with Input 128 / Output 100. Invert the adjustment mask to black.
2. Choose a large soft white brush, roughly 700-900 px, Flow 10%. Paint partly off-canvas at the corners to reveal gentle edge darkening.
3. Protect the crow's upper wing, the wrist and any important lightning branch. The vignette should not create a visible circular spotlight.
4. Toggle it. Reduce the adjustment opacity when it is obvious. Save the PSD without flattening.

WHY Edge darkening can focus attention, but it should remain revisable. A mask is easier to tune than a permanently filled black border.

CHECK The central visual path stays clear. Corners are slightly quieter without losing essential subject detail.

FIX Dark ring or abrupt oval? Use a much larger soft brush and lower flow; repaint the mask rather than blurring the whole artwork.

Source relationship: PDF step 33 adapted; masked Curves replace a filled border. **Tools:** S2, S5.

07 / REVIEW & DELIVER

Inspect the four places that reveal a composite

STEP 37 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Main PSD at 100%, with the Layers panel visible.



Four checks: silhouette, transformation, secondary subject, effect boundaries.

1. Inspect the hand edge and wrist: no white fringe, missing skin or background holes. Test temporarily against both dark and white check layers with background effects hidden.
2. Inspect the finger-to-snake joint: no hard rectangle, repeated eye, doubled fingertip or see-through seam. Confirm the snake still has two tongue tips.
3. Inspect crow feather gaps and eye: no white bridges or blurred duplicate head. Then inspect lightning/rain plates for rectangular borders, buildings or uncovered canvas edges.
4. Return to the complete image at 25%. Turn weather off and on. The underlying hybrid must still work on its own. Write down the single most important fix.

WHY Large effects can hide small failures at normal viewing size. A systematic inspection separates masking quality from atmosphere.

CHECK You can show a sound cut-out, a sound join, a readable bird and clean effect plates.

FIX Finding many faults? Repair structure and masks first, tone second, weather last. Fix the cause instead of stacking more finishing layers.

Source relationship: New formal review pass based on difficulties throughout the source tutorial. **Tools:** S2.

07 / REVIEW & DELIVER

Document one purposeful revision

STEP 38 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Your most important issue from the previous step.



Example revision target: weather density versus focal readability.

1. Capture a before screenshot or export a before JPEG. Name it Evidence/04_Before.jpg. Identify one issue in a sentence: for example, “The near rain hides the snake’s eye.”
2. Change one relevant control or mask. Examples: reduce near-rain opacity, align a scale patch, repair one feather gap, or remove an unjustified rim highlight.
3. Capture Evidence/05_After.jpg using the same crop and zoom. Explain the tool used and the visible improvement. “It looks better” is not sufficient evidence.
4. In the HTML notes, identify any prepared support you used. A support image can help you continue, but you still need to demonstrate the assessed technique separately.

WHY A before/after pair makes design reasoning visible. It shows what you can diagnose and control, not merely that you reached the last page.

CHECK The comparison uses the same view and has a specific explanation linking the problem, tool and result.

FIX Changed ten things at once? Choose a smaller revision. Reopen the previous PSD version or document the next controlled change clearly.

Source relationship: New evidence and reflection requirement. **Tools:** Classroom addition.

07 / REVIEW & DELIVER

Save the layered master and export the artwork

STEP 39 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

The final main PSD, not an internal Smart Object tab.



The required artwork export is a landscape composite; the poster is optional.

1. Choose File > Save As and save Working/Lastname_Stormbound_v03.psd. Keep layers and Smart Objects. Enable Maximize Compatibility when Photoshop asks.
2. Choose File > Export > Export As. Select JPG, keep 1440 × 900 pixels and choose a high-quality setting. Enable Convert to sRGB; embed the colour profile when that option is available.
3. Save Exports/Lastname_Stormbound_Final.jpg. Reopen that JPEG to check that it matches the visible PSD and has no missing effects or guides.
4. Keep the layered master separate from the export. Save any open Smart Object edits before the final export, then back up the Working and Evidence folders.

WHY The PSD preserves decisions and editability. The JPEG is a portable viewing copy, not a replacement for the working source.

CHECK You have both a layered PSD and a final JPEG that opens correctly. The snake, bird, rain and highlights are all present.

FIX Export is a rain plate or cut-out? The wrong tab was active. Return to the main Stormbound document and export again.

Source relationship: New saving and delivery instructions. **Tools:** S3.

07 / REVIEW & DELIVER

Submit evidence, explain choices and credit sources

STEP 40 / 40 • SELECT FIRST

Your Exports, Working and Evidence folders plus process notes.

LAYER ORDER / A construction map, not a Photoshop screenshot	
07 FINISH	Gradient Map / vignette / optional live type
06 ATMOSPHERE	Mist / splash / near rain / far rain
05 CROW	Light + shade adjustments / crow / masked wing trail
04 HYBRID	Subject light + shade / clone patch / snake / hand
03 LIGHTNING	Glow / bolts (Screen; mask buildings)
02 BACKGROUND	Clipped cloud adjustment / cloud Smart Object
01 CHECKS	Temporary light/dark backdrops; usually hidden

Progress checkboxes are a study aid, not automatic proof of skill or a grade.

1. Submit the final JPEG, layered main PSD, three technique checkpoints and your before/after revision pair using your teacher's submission system.
2. Answer: How did you make the neck continue the finger? Why did Screen work for the lightning? What makes the two rain layers feel like different depths?
3. Add a source list using the supplied filenames and the original tutorial credit. Identify any support cut-outs, rain plates or brush pack used; do not describe supplied work as your own extraction.
4. Use Export notes in the HTML guide to save a Markdown record, and Backup to save a restorable JSON file. Keep these files with the project. Do not publish third-party stock assets until their permissions have been checked.

WHY The finished product, process evidence and explanation together reveal your understanding. Credits and support declarations make authorship clearer.

CHECK Another person can open the export and understand the process. Your notes name actual tools, decisions and source files.

FIX Progress boxes checked but no work saved? The guide does not contain your PSD. Export notes and separately submit the artwork files.

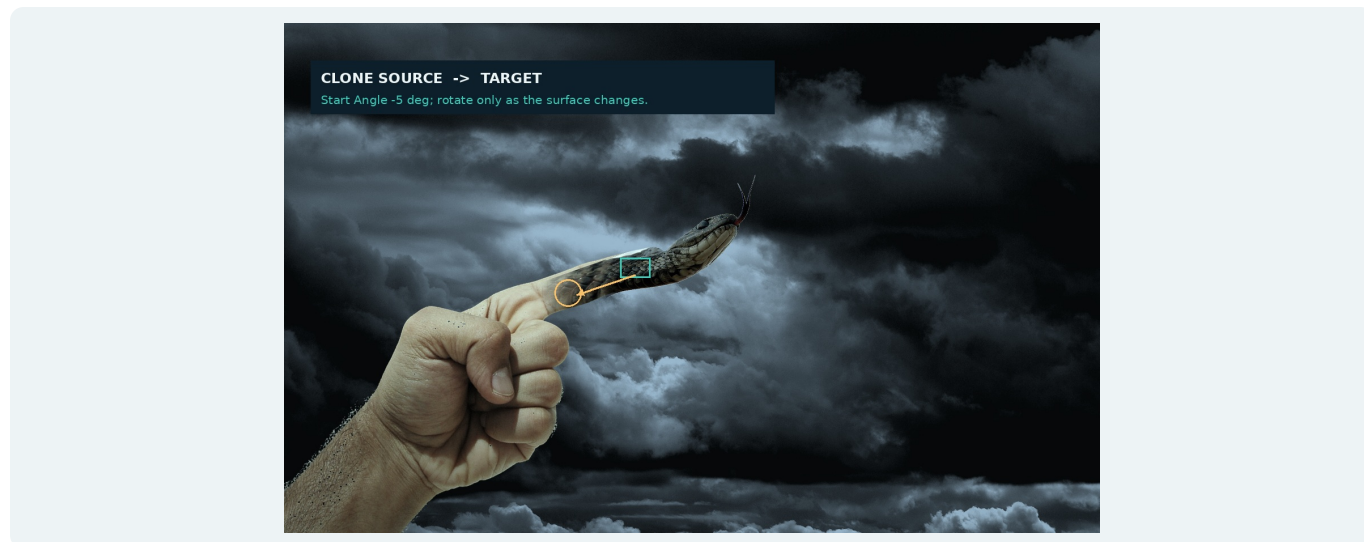
Source relationship: New submission and authorship requirement. **Tools:** Classroom addition.

EXTENSION / TEXTURE CONTROL

Extend the scales around a second curve

EXTENSION 1 • SELECT FIRST

A new Scale_Clone_02 pixel layer above Scale_Clone, with its own hand-shaped mask.



Extension is a separate demonstration of texture control, not extra decoration for its own sake.

1. Choose one small additional area: the side of the thumb or a narrow strip on the forearm. Do not cover the whole hand.
2. Use Clone Stamp, Current & Below, Aligned, small strokes. Sample an interior neck texture and change Clone Source rotation to follow the local curve; test near 10-20° and adjust visually.
3. Mask the patch edges irregularly and preserve skin folds, the thumbnail and the joint structure. Use a local clipped Curves adjustment only when a tonal correction is necessary.
4. Capture a close-up with an arrow showing texture direction. Explain why its source rotation differs from the finger patch.

WHY A second curved surface tests whether you understand texture direction rather than memorising one cloning angle.

CHECK Scale rows bend with the selected surface and do not erase anatomical landmarks.

FIX Patch looks like a sticker? Reduce its size and compare its direction with the skin's curve. Return to a cleaner sample.

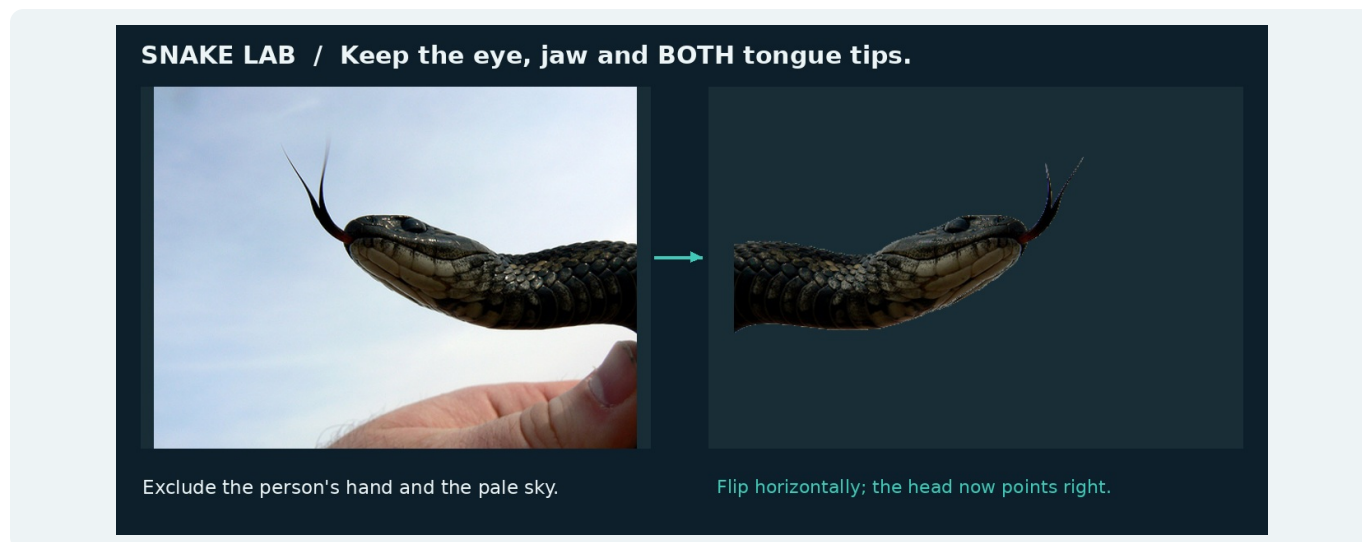
Source relationship: Develops PDF step 10. **Tools:** S8, S9.

EXTENSION / CONTROLLED MOTION

Suggest a flicking tongue without a second snake

EXTENSION 2 • SELECT FIRST

Snake Smart Object in 04_HYBRID.



The original contains a stronger tongue blur; this version favours silhouette readability.

1. Duplicate Snake and place the copy just below the original. Name it Tongue_Motion. Use Filter > Blur > Motion Blur with a small distance, about 6-10 px, and an angle that follows the fork's motion.
2. Add a black OUTSIDE layer mask to the duplicate. Reveal only a very small region behind the tongue tips with a white brush.
3. Keep the eye, jaw and neck completely hidden on the duplicate. Lower opacity to 15-25% and view at 100%.
4. Decide whether the effect improves motion or merely weakens the silhouette. Keep it hidden when the sharper version reads better.

WHY Small selective movement can reinforce the scene. Isolating the duplicate prevents an entire second head from appearing.

CHECK There is one sharp head, one recognisable fork and only a faint trail at its tips.

FIX The tongue becomes a blob? Reduce blur distance or omit the effect; the small source has limited detail.

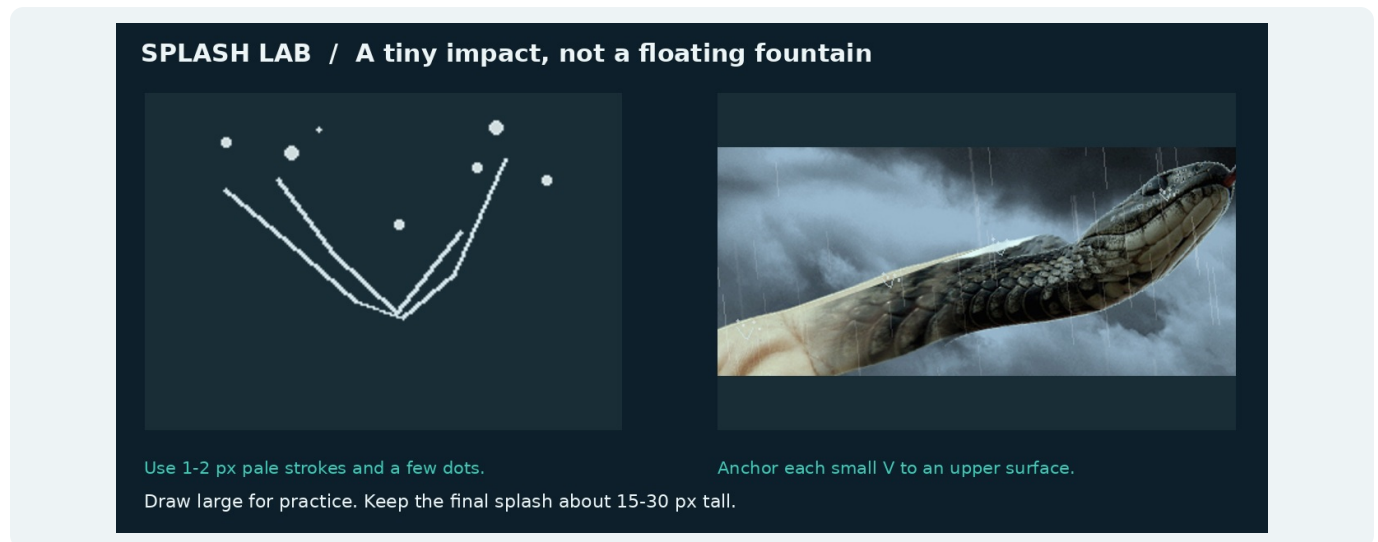
Source relationship: PDF step 17, optional rather than required. **Tools:** S2, S11.

EXTENSION / OPTIONAL BRUSH PACK

Try the legacy water brushes as an alternative

EXTENSION 3 • SELECT FIRST

Window > Brushes; use a blank test document before the main artwork.



ABR compatibility has not been tested here. The archive contains the ABR but no licence/readme.

1. Use the supplied SS-water.abr from optional_brushes in the classroom ZIP. In the Brushes panel menu choose Import Brushes and select the ABR file. Do not rename a ZIP to ABR.
2. Expand the imported group and inspect its thumbnails. The original PDF refers to presets “680” and “617”; do not assume current installations display those exact names or numbers.
3. Stamp once on a blank test layer. Try a small final size, then transform and mask the stamp before adding it to an impact point in the main artwork.
4. When the brush does not load, looks unsuitable, or its licence cannot be confirmed, keep the basic-brush method from steps 32-33. Record which method you used.

WHY The effect is the learning goal; an old brush-library dependency should not prevent completion. Importing the pack is an optional workflow comparison.

CHECK The splash is small, anchored and masked. You can still explain its placement without referring to a preset number.

FIX Nothing imports? Check the actual .abr file and school permissions. Do not spend the lesson troubleshooting a nonessential pack.

Source relationship: PDF steps 30-31 preserved as an optional legacy route. **Tools:** S12.

EXTENSION / GRAPHIC DESIGN

Turn the image into a fictional campaign poster

EXTENSION 4 • SELECT FIRST

A saved duplicate of the finished main PSD.



Fictional campaign concept; not an advertisement for a real event or film.

1. Save As Lastname_Stormbound_Poster.psd. Choose Image > Canvas Size, set units to pixels and size 1440 × 1080. Click the top-centre anchor so the extra 180 px is added below the artwork.
2. On a new shape layer draw a dark rectangle across the new bottom band. Use a colour such as #101E27. Do not cover the existing snake-hand join.
3. Use the Type tool to add STORMBOUND in a bold installed sans-serif font, about 62-74 px, with a left margin near 54 px. Add a short, smaller fictional tagline beneath it. Keep type live and editable.
4. Check hierarchy at 25%: title first, image second, tagline third-or explain a different intentional order. Export a separate poster JPEG and credit the artwork sources in your submission notes.

WHY The composite becomes a communication product with audience and hierarchy decisions, extending the technical exercise into graphic design.

CHECK The title is readable, the image is not squashed, and the new canvas space has a clear purpose.

FIX Image stretched vertically? Undo: change Canvas Size, not Image Size. Keep the original landscape version as a separate deliverable.

Source relationship: New optional application for Multimedia 12. **Tools:** Classroom addition.

FIND THE CAUSE, NOT ANOTHER EFFECT

Troubleshooting by symptom

Symptom	Check first / fix
White edge around hand or bird	View the mask on both light and dark backgrounds. Use a small local correction or modest negative edge shift; do not blur the whole subject.
Snake looks like a sticker	Align both contours, taper the root, keep overlap, then clone an interior scale patch and fade it irregularly.
Clone Stamp paints nothing	Select Scale_Clone pixels, not its mask. Use Current & Below; Alt/Option-click a visible source. Check that the target lies within the mask.
Cloud texture appears in cloned scales	The source crossed the snake edge. Undo, sample farther inside the neck, and shorten strokes.
Texture contains a second eye	Use interior neck scales, re-sample and vary the patch. Do not clone the face.
Adjustments change the entire sky	Check clipping arrows and the Normal blend mode of the subject group. Confirm the adjustment is inside the intended group.
Bird has a blurred second head	Hide the duplicate using its OUTSIDE layer mask. A Smart Filter mask hides blur, not the duplicate itself.
Lightning has a grey rectangle	Darken the source sky with Levels inside the plate and soften the perimeter mask. Screen does not hide nonblack sky.
Bright city dots float in clouds	Mask buildings, bridge lamps and windows out of the original lightning region.
Rain looks like television static	Check filter order: Add Noise first, Motion Blur second, Levels after the filtered seed.
Rain is an opaque grey curtain	Adjust the rain plate's black input and verify the outer layer is Screen. Then tune opacity.
Rain edits affect both depths	Use New Smart Object via Copy for an independent near-rain source, not an ordinary linked duplicate.

TEST ON THE SCHOOL INSTALLATION

Teacher preflight and pacing

Software and files

Open the source images and test saving a layered PSD. Confirm File > Place Embedded, Select and Mask, Clone Stamp Current & Below, Clone Source rotation, Convert to Smart Object, supported noise/blur Smart Filters and Export As. Cloud-assisted selection is optional; Quick Selection and Lasso provide fallbacks.

Critical ten-minute construction checks

Test a hand cut-out inside a Smart Object plus an outside placement mask; clone a short scale patch on a separate layer; make a Screen lightning plate; build one noise/blur/Levels rain plate and wrap it before transforming. Also confirm that New Smart Object via Copy makes the desired independent near-rain source.

Do not skip the difficult visual check

The source snake is small. Inspect the root taper and clone transition at the actual working size. Students should not be graded on detail that is absent from the source. A larger original would allow a larger final image, but none is supplied here.

Session	Suggested focus
1	Brief, file setup, layer groups, background and hand mask: steps 1-6.
2	Snake alignment, taper, cloning and transition: steps 7-15.
3	Crow, lightning and coherent relighting: steps 16-24.
4	Rain source, two depths and focal control: steps 25-30.
5	Wet details, restrained finish and quality checks: steps 31-37.
6 / flexible	Revision, evidence, export and an optional extension: steps 38-44.

Supports without removing the thinking

Offer a prepared cut-out after a timed selection attempt, then ask the student to repair an edge and explain a mask. A supplied rain plate does not demonstrate rain construction: collect a separate source-recipe screenshot or short live demonstration.

Permissions and accessibility

Confirm stock-image and brush permissions before sharing publicly. Use the basic-brush route when ABR import is blocked. Keep the PDF available for students who find scrolling difficult. Treat suggested pacing as a plan, not a guaranteed completion time.

OBSERVATION • CONVERSATION • PRODUCT

A manageable assessment

Three compact checks

Observation: ask the student to select the correct pixel/mask target, change a Clone Source angle or reopen the rain recipe. Conversation: ask why the skin-to-scale join works and how lightning determines highlights. Product: inspect the layered PSD, JPEG and one documented revision.

Criterion	Evidence to inspect	Points
1. Structure and masking	Contours align; no double fingertip, missing tongue or obvious pale feather gaps. Masks remain editable.	/ 4
2. Texture integration	Scale_Clone is separate; sampled texture follows the finger; transition is gradual and avoids repeated recognisable details.	/ 4
3. Light and tone	Subject brightness/colour suit the clouds; local highlights face the chosen bolt; no indiscriminate glowing outline.	/ 4
4. Motion and weather	Head stays sharp; two rain depths share direction; effect rectangles/buildings are absent; impacts touch surfaces.	/ 4
5. Revision and explanation	Before/after comparison identifies a problem, relevant control and visible improvement; sources/supports are declared.	/ 4

Suggested anchors for each criterion

4: convincing, controlled and independently explained. 3: the essential technique works with minor local flaws. 2: partly successful, with inconsistent control or an explanation that needs prompting. 1: limited visible evidence of the technique. 0: no assessable evidence yet. These are suggested classroom criteria, not official curriculum outcome codes.

Score and feedback

Add the five criterion scores for a suggested total out of 20. A percentage can be calculated as $\text{total} \div 20 \times 100$, if required by the teacher's gradebook. Do not award extra marks simply for adding more effects or completing optional extensions.

One useful feedback sentence

"Your [specific technique] is working because [visible evidence]. Next, change [one control or mask] to improve [one observable result]."

MAKE THE REASONING VISIBLE

Student reflection and evidence

1 / Explain the transformation

Where did your snake source end and your cloned transition begin? Describe how you matched the two contours, selected a sample, changed its direction and faded the patch.

2 / Explain the lighting

Identify your strongest light source and two surfaces that face it. Describe one place where you deliberately did not add a highlight.

3 / Explain the weather

Why does a black-backed lightning plate work in Screen? What changes between the far and near rain? How did you keep the focal details visible?

4 / Explain the revision

Problem: _____ Tool/control: _____ Before/after evidence:
 _____ Visible improvement: _____

5 / Declare support and source use

List prepared cut-outs, plates or brushes used. State which parts you built yourself and which technique you demonstrated separately. Keep the original tutorial credit and the supplied image filenames.

Evidence filename	What it shows
01_Join.jpg	Hand-to-snake transition, with Scale_Clone visible in the Layers panel.
02_Lighting.jpg	One lighting mask and an explanation of the bolt direction.
03_Rain_Depth.jpg	Near/far layers or the source recipe, with depth decisions.
04_Before.jpg + 05_After.jpg	Same zoom/crop for one purposeful correction.
Process_Notes.md	Exported notes, answers, sources and support declaration.

Submission check

Main layered PSD; final JPEG; three technique checkpoints; before/after revision pair; process notes and credits. The guide's checkboxes are not a substitute for these files.

SOURCE CROSSWALK

What comes from the original?

Original PDF	This edition	Relationship
Steps 1-2 / pp. 2-3	Steps 1-6	Same canvas and hand composition; expanded file setup, masks and controls.
Steps 3-6 / pp. 3-7	Steps 7-11	Same flipped/warped snake continuation; protect head proportions and retain editability.
Steps 7-10 / pp. 7-14	Steps 12-14 + 41	Same Clone Source technique; blank target layer and masks replace erasing.
Steps 11-15 / pp. 14-22	Steps 4, 15-18, 22-23	Same hand/sky/bird integration; order adjusted and lighting made editable.
Steps 16-17 / pp. 23-28	Steps 24 + 42	Selective motion retained; tongue movement becomes optional.
Steps 18-22 / pp. 29-37	Steps 4, 19-23	Lightning and highlights retained; Screen is a stated alternative to Vivid Light.
Steps 23-29 / pp. 37-43	Steps 25-30	Noise-based rain retained; nested editable plate, two depths and focal masks added.
Steps 30-32 / pp. 44-50	Steps 31-33 + 43	Surface impacts retained; basic brush is core and the ABR is optional.
Steps 33-34 / pp. 51-54	Steps 35-36	Vignette and shared finish retained; adjustment methods/grade differ.
No direct counterpart	Steps 34, 37-40, 44	Mist choice, systematic inspection, revision evidence, delivery and poster are new.

Preserved intent

The scene remains a finger becoming a snake, balanced by a crow in a lightning-and-rain environment. It is not replaced with an unrelated generative image or a simple snake pasted over a hand.

Researched updates versus source facts

References S2-S12 verify tool mechanisms and menu families. Exact settings, composition anchors, scaffolding and assessment in this edition are proposed teaching choices unless identified as retained from the original.

PROVENANCE & HONEST LIMITATIONS

Source credits and asset boundaries

Tutorial basis

Alvaro Guzman, Design a Dramatic and Surreal Rainy Scene with Photoshop, Envato Tuts+, 21 January 2009. Based on the user-supplied Word - Snakyfinger.pdf, whose print stamp is 30/09/2009. Preserve the original author/title in adapted classroom credits.

Photographs and diagrams

All eight original image files in this package were supplied by the user. Their filenames and pixel dimensions are recorded in the asset manifest. Some filenames suggest stock origins, but names alone do not establish a photographer, licence or redistribution permission. No blanket licence is claimed.

Legacy water pack

SS_water.zip was inspected and contained SS-water.abr only; no licence/readme was found in that archive. The supplied ABR is included unmodified in optional_brushes for the requested classroom work, pending the teacher's permissions check. Its import was not tested here.

Prepared supports and illustrations

The new cut-outs, compositing checkpoints and teaching diagrams were prepared from the supplied photographs using image-processing tools. They illustrate expected relationships but are not Photoshop screenshots. Rain proof images use illustrative random streaks; exact Photoshop noise results will differ. Original_PSD_Reference.jpg is the legacy merged preview and retains its watermark.

Not packaged as student starters

The original legacy PSDs and the original PDF remain the user's separate uploads. The student core starts from five photographs. Avoid handing out a finished legacy PSD as independent construction evidence.

Scope of verification

The PDF and HTML can be checked here for layout and interaction. The full workflow has not been performed inside Photoshop. The teacher must preflight the installed application, source rights and browser note storage before independent classroom use.

No font distribution

The resource uses installed/system fonts. No standalone font files are included. Students should select an available licensed font for the optional poster.

SOURCE NOTES & VERIFIED TOOL REFERENCES

References 1 / 2

The supplied PDF is the basis of the scene. Adobe references verify tool behaviour; new recipes and classroom choices are labelled in the step footers. Accessed September 2026.

S1 / Original concept and sequence

Alvaro Guzman, "Design a Dramatic and Surreal Rainy Scene with Photoshop," Envato Tuts+, 21 January 2009. The supplied Word - Snakyfinger.pdf is a 55-page printout carrying a 30/09/2009 print stamp. Original title, 34-step sequence and image relationships are the lesson basis.

[Open source](#)

S2 / Layer masks

Adobe: adding and editing visibility masks. Masks replace destructive erasing in this adaptation.

[Open source](#)

S3 / Smart Objects

Adobe: keeping source content embedded and editable, duplication and workflow limits. Cloning is performed on a separate pixel layer.

[Open source](#)

S4 / Clipping masks

Adobe: restricting the effect of layers to a base layer's visible shape.

[Open source](#)

S5 / Curves

Adobe: tonal adjustments using editable curve points and adjustment layers.

[Open source](#)

S6 / Selection edges

Adobe: refining and softening selection edges. The small settings in this guide are starting recipes for the supplied files, not universal defaults.

[Open source](#)

SOURCE NOTES & VERIFIED TOOL REFERENCES

References 2 / 2

The supplied PDF is the basis of the scene. Adobe references verify tool behaviour; new recipes and classroom choices are labelled in the step footers. Accessed September 2026.

S7 / Transforms

Adobe: rotate/flip controls. Warp and placement choices in this guide are tailored to the source photographs.

[Open source](#)

S8 / Clone Stamp

Adobe: sampling and painting onto a target layer, including Current & Below.

[Open source](#)

S9 / Clone Source rotation

Adobe: scale or rotate the sample source, updated 23 February 2026.

[Open source](#)

S10 / Blend modes

Adobe: Screen, Color and other blending mode behaviours. The Screen lightning approach is an adaptation, not the original Vivid Light recipe.

[Open source](#)

S11 / Smart Filters

Adobe: supported filters, editable settings, bottom-up application order and filter-mask behaviour.

[Open source](#)

S12 / ABR import

Adobe: importing brush packs through Window > Brushes. The supplied legacy pack itself was not tested in Photoshop.

[Open source](#)